



DHANALAKSHMI SRINIVASAN GROUP OF INSTITUTIONS

TRICHY | PERAMBALUR | CHENGALPATTU | SIRUVACHUR

NOT ONE, NOT TWO.. THREE... TWO DEEMED-TO-BE UNIVERSITIES & ONE STATE PRIVATE UNIVERSITY.

For us, education has never been measured by the number of institutions we establish, but by the generations we educate, empower and inspire. What began as a commitment to school education has grown into a distinguished journey of academic excellence. Today, with two Deemed-to-be Universities and one Private University, we proudly mark another significant milestone in higher education, continuing our vision of shaping knowledge, creating opportunities and building futures for generations to come.



DHANALAKSHMI SRINIVASAN UNIVERSITY

(Established Under The Tamil Nadu Private Universities Act, 2019)
Samayapuram - 621 112, Trichy, Tamil Nadu, India

Medicine | Engineering & Technology |
Allied Health Sciences | Nursing | Physiotherapy |
Pharmacy | Occupational Therapy |
Agricultural Sciences | Law | Arts & Science |
Management | Architecture



DHANALAKSHMI SRINIVASAN INSTITUTE OF RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGY

(Deemed to be University Under Section 3 of the UGC Act)
Perambalur - 621 212, Tamil Nadu, India

Medicine | Agricultural Sciences |
Allied Health Sciences | Physiotherapy |
Arts and Science



DHANALAKSHMI SRINIVASAN INSTITUTE OF SCIENCE AND RESEARCH

(Deemed to be University Under Distinct Category
Section 3 of the UGC Act)
Siruvachur - 621 113, Perambalur, Tamil Nadu, India

Medicine | Dental | Nursing
Allied Health Sciences



On this proud occasion, we extend our heartfelt appreciation and gratitude to the students, parents, faculty, staff, administrative officials, well-wishers, and everyone who has contributed to this remarkable achievement.

FOR ADMISSIONS

Trichy : 1800 532 2222

dsu_trichy
dhanalakshmisrinivasanuniversity
Dsntry_official
dhanalakshmisrinivasanuniversity
DSU-trichy-campus

Perambalur : 1800 889 6622

ds.university.perambalur
Dhanalakshmi Srinivasan University, Perambalur
dsuniversityofficial
dhanalakshmi-srinivasan-university-perambalur
DSU_Perambalur

Chengalpattu : 78258 28303

dsuniversity_chennai
Dhanalakshmisrinivasan
DSUmanandur
@DhanalakshmiSrinivasanUniv-Chen

Siruvachur : 94776 94776

dsnmch.official
Dhanalakshmi Srinivasan Medical College and Hospital
Dhanalakshmi Srinivasan (DSMCH) Medical College and Hospital
@DhanalakshmiSrinivasanMedicalCollege & Hospital

Shri. A. SRINIVASAN

Hon'ble Chancellor,
Dhanalakshmi Srinivasan University

Timings	
DELHI	
MONDAY, SEP. 21	
RISE 06:09	SET 18:19
RISE 15:12	SET 00:46
TUESDAY, SEP. 22	
RISE 06:09	SET 18:18
RISE 15:49	SET 01:44
WEDNESDAY, SEP. 23	
RISE 06:10	SET 18:17
RISE 16:22	SET 02:41

Delhi Weather	max	min
Delhi City	35	25
Safdarjung	35	25
Palam	34	24

Delhi Palam Today
35°C Morning will be pleasant with mist and haze. The weather will be dry. Day will be warm with uneasy afternoon. Night will be comfortable.

Delhi Palam Tomorrow
36°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm and uneasy. Night will remain comfortable.

© Copyright SkyMet Weather 2026
 All rights reserved.

**TO ADVERTISE
PLEASE CONTACT**
Mr. N SELVA KUMAR
PH: 9820350726
 selvakumar@thehindu.co.in

THE HINDU
 India's National Newspaper

**Your feedback will keep us
Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder**

Call our toll-free number
1800 102 1878
 Or write to us at
 customercare@thehindu.co.in

Scan the QR code to register your feedback

THE HINDU **businessline**
ENTERTAINMENT **SPORTS** **TECHNOLOGY** **TRAVEL**

THE HINDU

DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. The PUBLISHER, THE HINDU, the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not warrant or undertake to be held responsible for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
 (A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
 No. 2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar,
 Bengaluru-560009. Phone No. 080-22265383, Website: www.kiadb.in

No. IADB/ENG/ETND-EP-38/8361/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
 (Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

Item Rate Tenders under two cover bid system are invited as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Contractors who have got adequate financial resources, state of the art technology, suitable construction equipments, technical man power & sufficient past experience for the work of:

Name of the Work: (1) Formation of asphalt road including construction of RCC Side drains, Deck slab and water supply pipeline at Road No. 1, 2 & 11 at Sub layout-8, Koorgalli Industrial Area, Mysuru Taluk, Mysuru District. (2nd Call)
 (2) Formation of Asphalt Road including Construction of RCC side Drains, Deck slab and water supply pipe line at Sub Layout 3, Badanaguppe-Kellamballi Industrial Area, Chamara Nagar Taluk, Chamara Nagar District.

The last date and time of receipt of tender is: **06.10.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**
 Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>.

Sd/-
Engineer in Chief, KIADB, Bengaluru

DPR/CP/2843/SMCL/2026-27

UTTARAKHAND POWER CORPORATION LIMITED
 (A Govt. of Uttarakhand Undertaking)
 V.C.V. Gagar Singh Urja Bhawan, Kanwal Road, Dehradun-248001, Corporate I.D. No. UAM0108UR2001SGC025867/2358
 Ph. No.: 0135-2763872-75, Fax: 0135-2763830, Website: www.uktdens.gov.in

E-TENDER NOTICE
TENDER SPECIFICATION NO. 16 to 18 /SE(MM)/2026-2027

Superintending Engineer (MM), Uttarakhand Power Corporation Ltd., V.C.V. Gagar Singh Urja Bhawan, Dehradun invites e-tender for the sale of obsolete Power Transformers of various capacities (1.5 MVA, 3/3 15 MVA, 5MVA & 8MVA) on 'AS IS WHERE IS BASIS' available at different Stores Centers/ Substation under Electricity Store Division Dehradun/Haldwani. The last date of online request of tender document/submission opening date of tender are as given below:-

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of Store center at which Transformer is available	Name of Material	Qty (Unit)	Average Turnover for Previous 3 Years (In Rs.)	Earnest Money (FDR/CDR) (In Rs.)	Cost of tender document including GST (Draft) (In Rs.)	Last Date & Time of online request for purchase of the tender document & submission of tender in online & off-line mode	Date of opening of Bid part list in online & off-line mode
1	Tender No. 16/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESC Dehradun/ Rishikesh/ Roorkee/ Haridwar/Kotdwara under Electricity Store Division, Dehradun	Power Transformers of various capacities (1.5MVA-09 Nos, 3MVA-15 Nos & 5 MVA- 31 & 8 MVA-07 Nos)	62 Nos	1913.94 Lacs	25.52 Lacs	29500 00	16.10.2026 Upto 17.00 Hrs	17.10.2026 Upto 15.00 Hrs
2	Tender No. 17/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESC, Srinagar/Charnoli under Electricity Store Division, Dehradun	Power Transformers of various capacities (1.5 MVA-1 Nos & 3/3 15MVA-11 Nos)	12 Nos	311.61 Lacs	3.12 Lacs	11800 00	16.10.2026 Upto 17.00 Hrs	17.10.2026 Upto 15.30 Hrs
3	Tender No. 18/SE(MM)/2026-2027	ESC, Haldwani/Sitarganj/ Kashipur/Rudrapur/ Tanakpur under Electricity Store Division, Haldwani	Power Transformers of various capacities (1.5 MVA-12 Nos, 3/3 15MVA-12 Nos, 5 MVA-14 Nos & 8 MVA-3 Nos)	41 Nos	1085.65 Lacs	14.48 Lacs	23600 00	16.10.2026 Upto 17.00 Hrs	17.10.2026 Upto 16.00 Hrs

For further details, please visit website www.uktdens.gov.in.
 No.: 744/EEI(cml)/UPCLIA-2 Dt.: 19.09.2026

Superintending Engineer (MM)
 "SAVE ELECTRICITY IN THE INTEREST OF THE NATION" Use LED Bulb to Save Electricity (Toll Free No. : 1912)
 "Pay Electricity Bill Online 24x7 from www.upcl.in"
 (For information on Electricity theft, informer may report to Toll Free No. : 1800 180 4185/ 1800 419 0405, Fax No. 0135-2760911)

BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED
 Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWM, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanthi Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 052

No. DGM-1/BSWML/Tend/16/2026-27 Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER call-03 (Only through GOK KPP Portal Only)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWM, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl No	Name of Work	Amount Put to Tender per annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (In Rs)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Rajajinagara division (Package-9) Call-03	1,344.67	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.14,00,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized / scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

Calendar of events: (1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal : **22.09.2026.** (2) Last date to upload pre bid queries in KPP Portal : **24.09.2026 before 17.30 hrs.** (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting : **25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office.** (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : **05.10.2026 before 17.00 hrs.** (5) Opening of Technical Bid: **06.10.2026 after 17.30 hrs.**

More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

DPR/CP/2843/SHRDI/SAI/2026-27

CLASSIFIEDS MART

TO ADVERTISE VISIT
www.thehinduads.com
CALL: 011-43579797

EDUCATIONAL

GENERAL

ANTHRO MEANS VOID SIR
 Scan to View All Courses

Mitra's IAS
 Learn Here, Lead Anywhere
PHILOSOPHY
 Don't Choose Optional. Choose Rank.
FRESH BATCH 05 OCT 5 PM
 Maximum Impact Optional
 Boosts Essay & Ethics

ESSAY CLASSES + MENTORSHIP
 ESSAY SCORE TRANSFORMATION
 40+ Years of Experience
 100% Success Rate
 8826469839

PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, SUSHIL Kumar, s/o Late Sh. Ram Kumar Tyagi, r/o 4-157, A Block Near Deep Memorial Senior Secondary School, Rampuraha, Ghaziabad, U.P.-201011. Change My Name To Sushil Kumar Tyagi

TENDERS

Oushadhi
 The Pharmaceutical Corporation
 (U.K.) Kerala Ltd.
 (A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking)
 Kuttanallur, Thrissur-14, Kerala
 Ph: 0487-2459841, 2459807, 2459842
 Email: purchase@oushadhi.org

TENDER NOTICE
 OUSH/86/2026-PSA1 19-09-2026

Tenders are invited for the supply of Raw Materials for the period 01.11.2026 to 31.03.2027. Tenders can be downloaded from www.oushadhitender.com. For more details visit Oushadhi website www.oushadhi.org or contact our Purchase Division at Kuttanallur, Thrissur.

(Sd/-) Managing Director

EDUCATIONPLUS

GET THE EDGE Follow us facebook.com/thehindu x.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

Y.R.M. Rao

Every year, higher education institutions invest significant effort in attracting students through advertisements, outreach programmes, educational fairs, and admission campaigns. Many expert faculty members to participate in admission-related and various administrative activities that extend beyond their core academic roles. While student enrolment and institutional sustainability are undeniably important, the increasing diversification of faculty time towards non-academic functions often leaves limited scope for meaningful engagement in research, innovation, and scholarly pursuits.

Consequently, many institutions continue to be evaluated primarily on examination results, placements, and admissions rather than on their contribution to knowledge creation. In an era driven by innovation and global competitiveness, this calls for a re-examination of institutional priorities. The true strength of a higher education institution lies not merely in the number of students it admits or graduates, but in its ability to generate new knowledge, solve real-world problems, and contribute to societal progress through sustained research and innovation.

As India aspires to emerge as a global knowledge hub, institutions must

Beyond results and admissions

Higher education institutions require a clear academic vision supported by four interconnected pillars: research publications, scholarly books, patents, and funded research projects



move beyond their traditional role as centres of instruction and evolve into centres of discovery, innovation, and intellectual leadership. This transformation requires a clear academic vision supported by four interconnected pillars: research publications, scholarly books, patents, and funded research projects. Together, they strengthen the profile of individual faculty members while elevating the institution's reputation and impact.

Research: The publication of quality research papers, which are the most visible expression of scholarly activity and intellectual contribution, enables faculty members to share new findings, challenge existing assumptions, and advance knowledge within their disciplines. Publications in reputed journals enhance academic visibility, encourage collaboration, and establish credibility among peers. More importantly, research-active faculty members bring fresh perspectives into the classroom, ensuring that students learn not only established concepts but also emerging developments shaping their fields. This transforms teaching from the transmission of existing knowledge into an engagement with new knowledge.

Publications: Books and scholarly works represent a deeper and more comprehensive engagement with a subject than is often possible through articles alone. They allow edu-

cators to synthesise knowledge, document experiences, and present original insights in a structured manner. Scholarly writing contributes to the academic ecosystem by creating valuable resources for students, researchers, and professionals. Faculty members who author books help build intellectual capital that continues to influence learning long after individual lectures have ended.

Innovation: Research achieves its fullest value when it moves beyond theory and finds practical application. Patents recognise originality and demonstrate the researchers' ability to transform ideas into useful products, processes, or technologies. They serve as evidence that academic work can address industrial, technological, and societal challenges. Institutions that promote innovation and patent generation cultivate a culture of creativity, problem-solving, and entrepreneurship, which are increasingly essential in the modern knowledge economy. Patents also strengthen the links between academia and industry, ensuring that research outcomes contribute directly to economic and social development.

Funded research projects: Securing grants from government agencies, industries, and international organisations testifies to the quality and relevance of a researcher's ideas. Funded projects provide resources to investigate com-

plex problems, develop infrastructure, foster interdisciplinary collaboration, and engage students in meaningful research experiences. They often lead to a cycle of publications, patents, consultancy opportunities, and societal impact. Institutions with strong research funding portfolios are generally better positioned to contribute to national priorities and global academic discourse.

The responsibility to strengthen these four pillars does not rest solely with faculty members. Management and academic administrators must create enabling environments through supportive policies, research infrastructure, incentives, reduced procedural barriers, and a culture that values scholarly achievement. Faculty members, in turn, must view research not as an additional obligation but as an integral component of their academic identity. When these efforts converge, institutions become more than centres of teaching; they become centres of knowledge creation and innovation. Faculty members are appointed not just to teach existing knowledge but also to create new knowledge; institutions that recognise this distinction are the ones that ultimately lead rather than follow.

The writer is an academic, administrator, researcher, and author with over four decades of experience in Engineering education and institutional development.

SCHOLARSHIPS

LIC Golden Jubilee Scholarships
 Offered by the LIC Golden Jubilee Foundation.
Eligibility: Students who have secured at least 60% in Classes 10 and 12 in the 2023-24 to 2025-26 academic years. For the General Scholarship, applicants must be in the first year of one of the listed academic programmes in 2026-27. For the Special Scholarship, applicants must be in the first year of intermediate, vocational or diploma courses. Annual family income must not exceed ₹450,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹50,000.
Application: Online
Deadline: September 30
www.b4s.in/edge/LICCI

Central Sector Scheme of Scholarship for College and University Students
 Offered by the Ministry of Education, Government of India.
Eligibility: Indian nationals with minimum 80% in Class 12 from a recognised institution who are enrolled in a professional programme and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹450,000.
Rewards: ₹20,000/year
Application: Online
Deadline: September 30
www.b4s.in/edge/CSSS

Courtesy: Buddy4Study.com



INDIA'S PRIDE
Elavenil & Co. open Nagoya account
SPORT » PAGE 15

DRONE BARRAGE
Ukraine attack kills 2 in Russia, hits refinery
WORLD » PAGE 14

DATA POINT
The paradox of self-reliance
China-centric supply chains create an 'assembly trap' for India
OPINION » PAGE 7

DELHI SIR
Top poll official, late economist on notice list
NEWS » PAGE 10

IN BRIEF

Police arrest 12 DTC bus drivers for 'vandalism'

The Delhi police on Saturday arrested 12 bus drivers for allegedly damaging public property in Rohini district amid the ongoing strike by the DTC drivers, which entered its sixth day. The 12 were arrested for allegedly damaging bus windows during the strike, said an officer. » **Page 2**

Kurmis will be kept out of UCC ambit: Suvendu

KOLKATA
West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday said the Kurmi community would be kept outside the ambit of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC). The Kurmis are a prominent community in the State's Jangalmahal region. » **Page 11**

Tata Sons Board did not meet conditions: Trusts

Reappointment of Chandrasekaran invalid, it says, challenging the casting vote mandate at Sept. 17 Board meeting, says resolution didn't have majority support from Tata Trusts-nominated directors

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Tata Trusts, the majority owner of Tata Sons, has challenged the validity of the holding company's September 17 decision to reappoint N. Chandrasekaran as the chairman of its Board, arguing that its Articles of Association (AoA) require affirmative support from both its Trust-nominated directors. A chairman's casting — or tie-breaking — vote cannot override that condition, Tata Trusts said.

In a statement issued on Sunday, Tata Trusts also denied the existence of any deadlock at the Tata Sons Board meeting on September 17. It insisted that the casting vote by the chairman of the meeting, inde-

Power dynamics

Tata Trusts has detailed provisions of the Articles of Association of Tata Sons to challenge the reappointment of Chandrasekaran

What the majority owner says

■ As per the AoA, any decision will need affirmative support of a majority of directors nominated by it

■ There are currently two directors, Venu Srinivasan and Noel Naval Tata, nominated by Tata Trusts, and a majority will need both their votes

■ While Mr. Srinivasan voted for the resolution on the chairperson, Mr. Tata voted against it, failing the AoA condition and the resolution



Noel Naval Tata

pendent director Harish Manwani, which led to the Board approving two crucial resolutions, had no *locus standi*.

The AoA "do not leave any decision of the Board to a mere head count of directors. They provide that no decision can be taken unless it has the affirmative

support of at least a majority of the directors nominated by the Tata Trusts, who hold approximately 66% of the company," Tata Trusts said in the statement.

Stating that this was a separate condition under the AoA, the Tata Trusts said, "There are two Tata

Trusts nominees on the Board of Tata Sons (Venu Srinivasan and Noel Naval Tata). Majority amongst two is two and not one."

'No deadlock'

"On September 17, 2026, one such director [Noel Naval Tata] voted against the resolution. Thus, the affirmative support of Tata Trusts nominee directors as mandated by the AoA was not given. The condition failed, and so did the resolution," Tata Trusts emphasised. The philanthropic body also denied any paralysis or deadlock arising from the "refusal of support" by Mr. Tata which would have entitled the chairman of the meeting to have a casting vote.

CONTINUED ON
» **PAGE 10**

Nepal keen to reset India ties: Minister

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

A month after the devastating Bhotekhoshi floods, Nepal Prime Minister Balen Shah will make his first foreign visit since assuming office in March, travelling to New York next week to address the UN General Assembly and discuss the country's recovery plans, Nepal Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle has said.

He also confirmed that Mr. Shah's first bilateral visit would be to India later this year, and that the new government was keen to "reset" ties and move away from "jingoism" over sovereignty issues and the border dispute that has led to tensions in the past. "The old era of jingoism and equating Nepali nationalism with anti-Indianism is over," Mr. Wagle said in an interview to *The Hindu* at the end of a three-day visit here on Saturday.

Mr. Wagle, an economist who has worked in



Swarnim Wagle

Nepal's planning commission and the UNDP, said his talks with Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar centred on the flood recovery plan, with Nepal also seeking to revise the 2009 Trade Treaty with India.

He also stressed the need for India to allow overflight permissions for international flights to Nepal's underutilised airports at Pokhara and Bhairahawa, which New Delhi has denied for the past decade citing security concerns.

INTERVIEW ON
» **PAGE 10**

IIT-B student 'suicide': Crime Branch to quiz faculty member

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

Mumbai Police Crime Branch is likely to summon IIT Bombay faculty member Suryanarayana Doola and others for questioning, sources said on Sunday.

Prof. Doola was booked on Saturday under various sections of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and for abetment to the suicide of 22-year-old student Sahil Wakode. The case was transferred to the Crime Branch later at night. The institute has said that Wakode, who was found dead in his hostel room on September 18, died by suicide after he was "caught" using a phone during an exam. Students have protested, demanding Director Shireesh Kedare's resignation. (For those in distress, counselling is available at Tele MANAS 14416)

Official Retail Banking Partner

TEAM INDIA

YES BANK

ASIAN GAMES 2026

INDIA HUMARE DIL MEIN

LIFE KO BANA O RICH

MANU BHAKER
Pistol Shooting

JASPRIT BUMRAH
Cricket

NEERAJ CHOPRA
Javelin Throw

HARMANPREET SINGH
Field Hockey

SAKSHI CHAUDHARY
Boxing

ABHISHEK SHARMA
Cricket

SCAN TO WATCH THE FILM



BJP workers staging a protest outside the AAP HQ on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

AAP councillor harassed MCD worker, alleges BJP, stages stir

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

BJP workers, led by North West Delhi MP Yogender Chandel, staged a protest outside the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) headquarters on Sunday demanding the dismissal of AAP councillor from Trikhopuri Vijay Kumar for allegedly harassing a sanitation worker of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and abetting his suicide.

"Why are [AAP chief] Arvind Kejriwal, [party's Delhi unit chief] Saurabh Bharadwaj and [area MLA] Kuldeep Kumar silent despite serious allegations against AAP councillor Vijay Kumar?" Mr. Chandel said. The police briefly detained several BJP workers and leaders, including the Lok Sabha member, during the protest.

The police said an FIR was registered against Mr. Kumar under Section 108 (abetment to suicide) of the BNS on September 14 after the sanitation worker's wife stated in her complaint that they had been trying to buy a house and obtained a loan with the AAP leader's assistance. She alleged that Mr. Kumar had taken possession of the loan amount and was harassing the worker. Mr. Chandel said his protest will continue its action against those responsible. (Those in distress can contact Tele MANAS at 14416 to seek help)

Police arrest 12 bus drivers for 'vandalism' as DTC drivers' stir over higher wages enters Day 6

Action taken against 12 for damaging bus windows, two FIRs registered, say police; some buses resume services, with govt. pressing former drivers into service; won't relent till demands, including hike in daily wages to ₹2,000, are met; protesters

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

The Delhi police on Saturday arrested 12 bus drivers for allegedly damaging public property in Rohini district amid the ongoing strike by the Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) drivers, which entered its sixth day.

The strike began on September 15, with drivers hired by private agencies on behalf of the DTC refusing to operate buses and stopping those already on the roads. The strike continued despite Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh's assurance on September 17 that the issue would be discussed with the private operators that employ the drivers.

According to a police officer, four of the 12 were arrested in Begumpur and the remaining in Khanjawa for allegedly damaging bus windows during the strike. FIRs have been registered in both areas under Section 3 of the Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act, 1984.

"The police are alleging that those arrested used a WhatsApp group of drivers



Buses parked at a DTC depot amid a drivers' strike in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

to investigate others to vandalise buses during the strike," said a driver from the Burari depot. "We will not back down until our demands are met," he added. The police, however, denied the allegation, saying the arrests were made only in connection with damage to public property.

On Sunday, some buses resumed services after the Transport Department brought in over 2,000 former DTC drivers, as well as drivers who had been promoted and deployed to other services, to operate

the buses. According to 2024 government data, there are about 4,564 contractual drivers in the city. The DTC Karamchahi Ekta Union said the number has increased since then and that there are now about 6,000 contractual drivers in the national capital.

'Rising privatisation' The drivers said increasing privatisation of bus operations had kept their salaries low, even as private operators had shirked responsibility for bus

maintenance.

"Our shift begins at 4 a.m. The duties (designated routes) are assigned without considering where a driver lives. Those travelling from far-off places have to wake up at 2 a.m., travel to work and do an eight-hour shift for a mere ₹862 a day," said Sanjay Gupta (name changed), a driver at the Wazirpur depot.

Ajay Bhatia, a driver at the Shadipur depot, alleged that they are forced to work 16 hours at a stretch. "We have no paid holidays, so we have to

work even if we are sick," he said.

Key demands

The drivers are demanding a "basic plus dearness allowance" salary structure, similar to government employees, with daily wages increased to ₹2,000. They are also seeking medical insurance and financial assistance in case of accidents and paid leave.

"The bus vendors don't come into the picture at all. Even when buses leave the depot in the morning, the employees responsible for checking them do not do their job properly, leading to breakdowns mid-route," said Sandeep Kumar, another driver from the Shadipur depot. "The fact that we do not have an educated and organised union is also affecting our strike," he added.

Meanwhile, AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj criticised the government over the strike, saying it was "causing inconvenience" to commuters while no relief had been provided to the drivers. "The drivers' salaries should be hiked to ₹3,200 a month," he added.

If 3-time CM gets SIR notice, what happens to common man: AAP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A day after former Chief Minister and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convener Arvind Kejriwal and four members of his family were issued notices after their names were flagged under the 'no mapping' category, the party's Delhi unit chief Saurabh Bharadwaj on Sunday questioned the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) drive, asking what would happen to an ordinary citizen if the voter details of a three-time Chief Minister were not mapped in the exercise.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Mr. Kejriwal were among the 33.1 lakh electors to whom notices were issued, according to the list published by the Chief Electoral Officer of Delhi on September 18.

At a press conference on Sunday, Mr. Bharadwaj said, "Three-time CM Arvind Kejriwal has been served a notice under the SIR process because, according to the SIR procedure, the names of Arvind Kejriwal, his wife and his children are not being mapped... What will happen to an ordinary person? That person has neither contacts nor networking nor access to the media."

Mr. Bharadwaj said approximately one-third of the names have been del-



AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj termed the ongoing SIR exercise a 'fraud'. PTI

ed under the pretext of such 'shifted' voters and alleged that the Booth Level Officers (BLOs) are deleting the names of people even if they have moved to the house directly opposite.

'Poor will bear brunt'

Regarding the verification process for the Bharatiya Janata Party leaders, he questioned how the BLO found Ms. Gupta in Shalimar Bagh, claiming that she does not even live in the area.

"This is an absolutely open fraud in the name of SIR," the former Minister said, adding that poor people will bear the brunt of this "fraud".

"If the voter card of a poor woman is deleted, she will not be able to get a pink card and ₹1,000 of her earnings will be spent on bus fares. The children of poor people will not get admission to schools because they do not have voter IDs," he said.

RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGE 10

Three killed, 3 others hurt after truck rams auto in Sarita Vihar

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Three persons were killed and three others injured after a dumper truck rams a stationary mechanical crane and an autorickshaw carrying workers engaged in installing

traffic cameras in south-east Delhi's Sarita Vihar, police said on Sunday.

The police identified the deceased as Umesh, 23, and Praveen, 35, both residents of Sangam Vihar, and Suraj, 34.

The three workers injured in the incident are

Akash, 20, Anup, 26, and Khem Singh, 40, a police officer said.

"The dumper driver has not been identified and remains untraced," the officer said, adding, "An investigation is under way to ascertain the circumstances leading to the collision."



CM Rekha Gupta at an event in New Delhi on Sunday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Manipur musician's murder revives fears of racism, harassment among Northeast residents in Kilokari

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two weeks after 54-year-old Manipuri musician Chongtham Vikram Singh was beaten to death in Kilokari village in south-east Delhi, residents say years of racial slurs, harassment, stereotyping and attacks have left them feeling like outsiders despite building lives in the area.

For Chandam Miroda Devi, 38, who lives directly below the house where Singh was assaulted, the sound of his cries, men rushing up and down the stairs and the assault continue to haunt her.

'Unable to sleep'

"I am unable to sleep. The sounds of that night keep rewinding in my head. I fear someone is knocking at my door. They came to his house and assaulted him, causing his death. How safe are we?" she said.

Reliving the night, Ms. Devi said she did not initially realise the chaos would lead to the death of a neighbour she had known for a decade.

Around 4 a.m., she received a call from a community leader asking whether she knew about an assault in the house above. By 6.32 a.m., Singh breathed his last at the Holy Family Hospital, about three kilometres away.

For residents from the Northeast, the incident has revived fears that predate the killing by years. Kilokari, less than a kilometre from the Ashram metro station, is a densely packed neighbourhood of multi-storey buildings, small shops, salons and eateries.

Several residents from the Northeast have lived and worked here for years, some for over two decades, yet say they continue to face racial slurs, stereotyping and harassment. Ms. Devi said she had re-



A vigil for Chongtham Vikram Singh held in Imphal earlier this month. ANI

peatedly heard derogatory terms directed at people from the community.

"Despite living in our own country and the national capital, we are made to feel like outsiders. We were born in Manipur... is that our mistake? We came here to build our lives, work hard and pay our rents, but we still are not given even the bare minimum respect," she said.

'Become more cautious'

Since the killing, residents say they have become more cautious about stepping out, particularly in the evening.

The community met to discuss avoiding confrontations, arguments or retaliation when subjected to teasing or abuse.

Sangeeta Keisam, another resident, said the community felt watched and judged in the days immediately after the incident. "For three days, we were shocked and upset. We felt people were constantly watching us. We started feeling like outsiders," she said.

Residents say they often prefer living in clusters in areas including Kilokari, Safdarjung Enclave and Munirka because they feel safer among people from the same region.

But Ms. Keisam said this

has also resulted in generalisations about the community, with people judging their clothing, appearance and the fact that they tend to socialise in groups.

'Racism not new here'

Ruchida Sharma, who has lived in the area for about 20 years, said snatching, harassment, racist remarks and violence were not new to the neighbourhood.

"If it has been someone from another community objecting to loud music or a nuisance, perhaps it would not have escalated this way. There is a mindset that asks, 'Why are these outsiders telling locals what to do?' That thinking needs to change," she said.

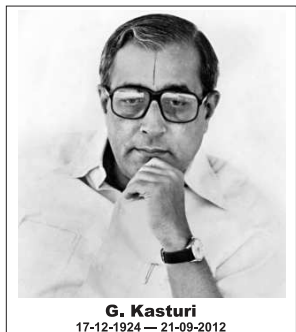
The police said the assault was triggered by "sudden provocation" and that the accused were not *prima facie* found to be drunk or under the influence of drugs, though medical reports are awaited.

The AIMS post-mortem examination found fractures in Singh's ribs, with bleeding and blood clots around the fractures. A laceration of the spleen was also recorded.

Seven men have been arrested and a minor apprehended in the case.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

IN MEMORIAM



G. Kasturi
17-12-1924 — 21-09-2012

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

EIGHTH ANNIVERSARY



N. RAMAMOORTHY, B.Com, B.L., FCA

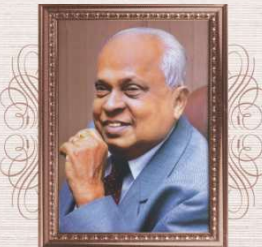
28-05-1963 - 21-09-2018

"Forever in our Hearts & Souls"

Father - Mother - Wife - Son - Daughter-in-Law - Brother - Sisters
'Sundaram', No.14, 54th Street, Ashok Nagar, Chennai - 600 083

IT'S HARD TO FORGET SOMEONE WHO GAVE YOU SO MUCH TO REMEMBER

Ninth Year Remembrance



Shri. M.K. Unnikhan

(1932 - 2017)

FOUNDER CHAIRMAN

SANKAR GROUP OF COMPANIES

Fondly Remembered and Revered by Family Members



REMEMBRANCE

SRI T.K. VARADARAJAN, Prathama Acharyapurna T.T.D., S/o Late Smt. Ranginayagi & Late S. T. K. Srinivasa Thathachari, Advocate, Madras, departed this day 2010. Dear Brother, Parents affectionately remembered.

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

To dedicate a space in this section, Please contact:

011-43579797 from 10 a.m. to 8 p.m.

For Placing Advertisements Online log on to

www.thehinduads.com

DONATE EYES - GIFT SIGHT

For enquiries on announcements in this section, please contact our office at the following number between 10a.m. to 8p.m.

New Delhi : 011-43579797

Rate for New Delhi : (Minimum Rs. 335/- 2 Lines Extra Line - Rs. 170/-)

(B/W Display): Rs. 65/Per Sq.cm (Clr Display): Rs. 75/Per Sq.cm

For Placing Advertisements Online log on to

www.thehinduads.com

Kerala University campus politics rules not finalised, says Minister

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Keralam Higher Education Minister Roji M. John has maintained that regulations prepared by Kerala University (KU) to regulate campus politics would be implemented only after stakeholder consultations.

According to the Minister, the university had tasked a subcommittee to frame a code of conduct for students. The decision had been taken following petitions filed before the Kerala High Court after the murder of Abhimanyu M., a second-



Keralam Higher Education Minister Roji M. John

year student and Students' Federation of India (SFI) leader, at Maharaja's College in Ernakulam in 2018. The court had directed universities to frame codes and suggested the code of conduct framed by Mahatma

Gandhi University in 2005 as a model.

The KU subcommittee subsequently entrusted the university's legal section with preparing a draft, which incorporated the provisions of the 2005 guidelines of Mahatma Gandhi University.

"The subcommittee will examine the document, propose amendments and seek views of student organisations and submit those with necessary amendments to the Syndicate [the university's executive body]. Any decision on student politics will require the Syndicate's approval,"

Mr. John said on Sunday.

Meanwhile, Leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan condemned the KU's move, calling it an attempt to drive political awareness out of campuses. In a post on Facebook, he wrote that regulating campus politics amounted to "depoliticisation". He alleged such decisions were part of an agenda of those unsettled by student movements that have emerged across the country.

University sources indicated that the backlash could prompt a revision of the proposed regulations.

Karnataka cancels 16 drug firms' licences

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Karnataka Food Safety and Drugs Administration (FSDA) has cancelled the licences of 16 pharmaceutical retailers and wholesalers and suspended those of eight others, including multinational firm Pfizer's depot in Nelamangala, in connection with a probe into the alleged distribution and sale of spurious drugs.

The action follows a probe into a large-scale unlicensed drug repacking and relabelling racket uncovered at a farmhouse in Bidadi on August 18.

Two die from electrocution near Ganesh pandal in Mumbai; Shelar asks mandals to prioritise safety

Chinmay Gaikwad
MUMBAI

Two individuals, including an eight-year-old girl, were killed and four others injured after they suffered electric shocks at a drinking water stall near a Ganesh pandal in Mumbai's Lalbaug in the early hours of Sunday, officials said. A 12-year-old who was among those injured is in a critical condition.

Following the incident, Maharashtra Cultural Affairs Minister Ashish Shelar asked Ganpati mandals to give highest priority to the safety of devotees and be vigilant

and responsible towards crowd management.

The incident occurred at 2.20 a.m. at the entrance of the Mahaganapati Utsav Mandal in Digvijay Mill Chawl in Kalachowki.

An eight-year-old girl, Raghini Ghanshyam Yadav, and a woman, Sujata, 33, died in the incident.

'Electrical fault'

Officials said an electrical fault was detected at a temporary stall selling drinking water and cold drinks near the pandal entrance. They said a short circuit had occurred at the spot.

Talking to reporters after visiting the hospital, Mr. Shelar said he met the father of Raghini and the husband of Sujata. "Ganeshotsav is a festival of faith, enthusiasm and social harmony. However, the safety of citizens and devotees must remain the highest priority during the celebrations. Every Ganesh mandal must strictly follow safety regulations in its area as well as the guidelines issued by the administration," he said.

The police have registered an FIR in connection with the incident, the Minister said. (With inputs from PTI)

Shri Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA

Shri Mohan Chanan Majhi
Chief Minister, Odisha

EKAMRA RESIDENCY

WHERE MODERN LUXURY MEETS NATURAL TRANQUILITY

The Bhubaneswar Development Authority invites online applications in the prescribed format for allotment of 496 (Four hundred ninety-six) flats in **EKAMRA RESIDENCY, Plot No-25(pt), Mouza: Subudhipur, Bhubaneswar through lottery.** The basic descriptions of the flats are as follows:

Type of Flats	Category	Total Flats Available	Carpet Area	Area of Balcony	Price (in Rs.)
2BHK + STUDY	1st Floor to 4th Floor	96	837.02 Sq.ft	88.37 Sq.ft.	₹94,90,173/-
	5th Floor to 8th Floor	96	837.02 Sq.ft	88.37 Sq.ft.	₹95,86,032/-
	9th Floor to 12th Floor	96	837.02 Sq.ft	88.37 Sq.ft.	₹96,81,893/-
2BHK	Ground Floor to 3rd Floor	64	665.18 Sq.ft.	83.02 Sq.ft	₹78,36,443/-
	4th Floor to 8th Floor	80	665.18 Sq.ft.	83.02 Sq.ft	₹79,15,599/-
	9th Floor to 12th Floor	64	665.18 Sq.ft	83.02 Sq.ft	₹79,94,755/-



ORERA Registration Number- RP/19/2021/00454 | RERA websites: <https://rera.odisha.gov.in>
occupancy certificate letter no-44380 / BMC Date: 28.07.2026



The allotment will be made through lottery only.

Receipt of Online application starts at 11.00 A.M on 18.09.2026
Receipt of Online application closes at 11.59 PM on 31.10.2026



For participation in the lottery, the applicants must pay a non-refundable Participation Fee/ Application Fee of Rs.10,000/- & the Security deposit (EMD) Rs. 2,00,000 to be deposited to the PNB Bank A/C, Account No - 0869102900000021, IFSC Code - PUNB0086910

Housing & Urban Development Department, Government of Odisha

OIPR-13001/13033226-27/0138
13001/1893/2627

CELEBRATING THE QUIET DREAMERS WHO DRIVE POWERFUL CHANGE.



They are the visionaries who dream quietly and act with intent. Their steady pursuit of progress turns belief into action, and action into a future we can all look forward to.

The Hindu businessline Changemaker Awards 2026 celebrates these leaders of change, recognising the ones who challenge the ordinary and set in motion ripples that transform lives and communities.

Join us live as we applaud the changemakers shaping tomorrow.



CHIEF GUEST

Smt. Nirmala Sitharaman

Honourable Minister of Finance and Corporate Affairs, Government of India



Scan the QR code or visit thbl.news/BLCM2026 to subscribe and watch the event.

SASTRA
DEEMED UNIVERSITY
THANJAVUR - KUMBakonam - CHENNAI

Presents

thehindubusinessline.



**CHANGE
MAKER
awards** RECOGNISING
HUMAN
CATALYSTS

Powered by

CITY UNION BANK

September 22 | 6 pm onwards | New Delhi

Presenting Partner

SASTRA
DEEMED UNIVERSITY
THANJAVUR - KUMBakonam - CHENNAI

Powered by

CITY UNION BANK

Associate Partners



Mobility Partner

States

IN BRIEF



Prashant Kishor announces names for Bihar Council polls

Jan Suraj Party (JSP) founder and Bankipur MLA Prashant Kishor on Sunday announced five candidates for the upcoming Bihar Legislative Council polls. The JSP has decided to field Divya Jyoti, S.P. Rai and Afaq Ahmed from Patna, Darbhanga and Saran teachers' constituencies respectively. Ravindra Yadav and Rajnish Ranjan will contest from Darbhanga and Kosi graduate constituencies. Candidates for the remaining constituencies — Tirhut teachers and Tirhut graduates and Patna graduates — will be announced in the next three to four days.

Rajasthan SI 2021 recruitment retest held across 11 districts

The Rajasthan Police Sub-Inspector and Platoon Commander Recruitment Re-examination 2021 was held across 11 districts on Sunday amid tight security, officials said. A total of 2,18,114 candidates registered for the re-examination, which was conducted at 666 centres. Candidates underwent biometric verification, facial recognition and frisking before being allowed to enter the examination centres to prevent malpractices. The re-examination was conducted four years after the recruitment examination was cancelled following a paper leak.

Gave jobs to 9.5 lakh, letters to 1 lakh more soon, says U.P. CM; joblessness rampant: Akhilesh

Recruitments have been transparent, merit-based under State govt.: Adityanath; people aggrieved, SP will cut BJP's votes in every constituency by 27,000 in Assembly election, says Oppn. party chief

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday criticised the Opposition over alleged irregularities, nepotism and corruption in recruitment, saying those who had turned Uttar Pradesh 'BIMARU' (sick) had no right to question the present government's record.

He said over 9.5 lakh youth had been given opportunities to serve in the State government since 2017 and announced that another 1 lakh would receive appointment letters within the next six months.

The acronym 'BIMARU' was coined in the mid-1980s, based on the names of the then poorest States — Bihar, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and U.P.

Samajwadi Party (SP) chief and former CM Akhilesh Yadav hit back at Mr. Adityanath, claiming, "The youth is facing large-scale unemployment. There are



U.P. CM Yogi Adityanath taking a selfie at a programme in Lucknow; SP president Akhilesh Yadav briefing the media on Sunday. ANI & PTI

no government jobs, and even where such jobs did exist, their rights have been systematically snatched away. Reservation has been snatched."

He added that his party has set a goal of reducing the BJP's votes by 27,000 in every Assembly seat. The Assembly poll is set to be held in U.P. next year.

'No more paper leaks'

Speaking at an event in Lucknow to distribute appointment letters to 912 candidates picked through

the U.P. Police Recruitment and Promotion Board's hiring process, Mr. Adityanath said the recruitment process before 2017 was marred by recommendations, illegal transactions, paper leaks, and discrimination. He asserted that the BJP-led government, which came to power after the 2017 election, made recruitment transparent and merit-based.

"Those who, through their inaction and inability, turned Uttar Pradesh into a BIMARU State have no

right to speak about U.P. Police or the administration of Uttar Pradesh," the Chief Minister said.

'People hit by price rise'

Addressing mediapersons in the State capital, Mr. Yadav said, "Today, we held a meeting with all the office-bearers and members of the state executive committee. We all have decided to work towards increasing our vote count by 27,000 in every Assembly seat. In other words, reducing the BJP's vote count by 27,000," he said.

He added that people from all walks of life are aggrieved. Farmers feel "betrayed", he alleged, adding that promises were made to double their income, but that has not happened.

"Prices of diesel, petrol, medicines, and fertilizer have all risen," he said.

Mr. Yadav also alleged that over 151 statues of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar had been vandalised across 72 districts during the BJP's nine-and-a-half-year rule in U.P.

Mann launches AAP's door-to-door drive in run-up to Punjab poll

Press Trust of India
DHURI

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday launched the Aam Aadmi Party's (AAP) door-to-door drive in the run-up to the 2027 Assembly poll.

Pitching his government's 'Mann Da Munafa' narrative, Mr. Mann claimed that every family is receiving an annual benefit of ₹1.82 lakh from its welfare initiatives like free electricity and health care.

He said AAP would go to every household with its record of work undertaken since 2022 while asserting that the campaign would remain positive and focus on what the government has delivered for Punjab.

Mr. Mann said AAP would seek people's support based on the work delivered on the ground and question the Opposition over its record and the issue of combating drugs.

During the outreach, the Chief Minister went door to door in Dhuri, met several families and interacted with elderly residents, women, youngsters, and children.

He listened to their views, discussed the work



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann

undertaken by the government over the past four and a half years and explained how various schemes and initiatives were translating into direct benefits for ordinary households.

'Not an abstract figure'

"Every family in Punjab is today benefiting by ₹1.82 lakh annually from the initiatives rolled out by our government. This is not an abstract figure. It represents money a household no longer has to take out of its own pocket for electricity, health care, education, and other essential services," Mr. Mann said.

"I want every family to sit down and calculate for itself how much that is saving every month. That is the real meaning of 'Mann Da Munafa'," he added.

Mahanadi water dispute will be resolved soon: Chhattisgarh CM

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday said the Mahanadi water dispute with Odisha is likely to be resolved "very soon", asserting that both States have agreed to accept the decision of the Centre on the matter.

Mr. Sai, on a two-day visit to Odisha, said the issue would be resolved because there are BJP governments in Chhattisgarh and Odisha and an NDA government at

the Centre.

"Both of us (Chief Ministers) have given consent to the Centre that we will accept whatever decision is taken by the Central Water Commission with regard to the Mahanadi issue," he said. Mr. Sai later met Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Mahi in the city.

'Fruitful interaction'

In a social media post, Mr. Mahi wrote that he had a "fruitful interaction" with his counterpart on strengthening cooperation between the two States, and advancing their shared commitment towards the welfare of people.

Mr. Sai's assertion that there was no longer a dispute over Mahanadi water distribution drew criticism from the Opposition Biju Janata Dal, which questioned whether Odisha's interests were being protected.

"The Chhattisgarh government is the creator of the Mahanadi water dispute. The statement of its CM that it is not a dispute is unacceptable," it stated.

'Why are students forced to live in unsafe PGs?': Rahul hits out at Modi govt. over hostel shortage

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday hit out at the Narendra Modi government over the issue of adequate hostel facilities for students. Mr. Gandhi asked why students are "forced to live in unsafe PGs (paying guest accommodations)" and also sought to know the status of the investigation into the Satya Niketan building collapse incident.

In a social media post,



Rahul Gandhi at a 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' event in Indore. PTI

Mr. Gandhi shared pictures from the interaction he had on Saturday in Indore with the family of a student from Madhya Pradesh who died in the Satya Niketan building collapse in Delhi on September 6.

Seven persons, including five students, died in the incident. Among them was 21-year-old Arpit Jai, a native of Dewas in Madhya Pradesh. Mr. Gandhi invited Jai's family on stage during his youth outreach programme 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' on Saturday.

'What was his fault?'

In his post in Hindi on X on Sunday, the Congress leader stated: "What was

that innocent soul's fault? This is the question being asked with tear-filled eyes by the family that lost their son in the Satya Niketan tragedy."

Had there been good and safe hostels, Jai's parents would not have been forced to house their son in such a dangerous place, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha said.

"Had safety standards truly been adhered to, perhaps this tragedy, would never have occurred," Mr. Gandhi said.

'Drought-hit taluks likely to cross 200 in Karnataka'

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

More than 200 taluks in Karnataka are likely to be declared drought-affected, Deputy Chief Minister and Revenue Minister G. Parameshwara said on Sunday.

He also accused the Centre of "discriminating against the State", adding that ₹17,000 crore due under the Jai Jeevan Mission is yet to be released.

SPOTLIGHT

Vikas Vasudeva

It has been over a week since Jish (name changed to protect privacy) arrived in India after completing his mandatory military service in Israel. He savours a lemon pie and ginger tea at a popular vegan bakery-cum-café located in the narrow market lane of Dharamkot, a misty village in Himachal Pradesh's rain-washed pine forests.

A popular destination among Israeli backpackers along the 'Hummus Trail', Dharamkot is about 2 to 3 km uphill from Mcleodganj. "This is my second visit to India," he says.

He felt compelled to visit last year in May, hearing stories through the drumbeat of social media and his friends' first-hand accounts. He stayed in the country for nearly five months, first alone, and then for two and half months with his wife.

Dharamkot is known as 'Mini Israel' because a number of Israelis flock here after they complete their conscription terms. Around 80,000 Israelis visit India annually, according to a paper, "Decoding the hummus trail of India: regaining the lost prudence", published in 2022 in *Anatolia*, an international journal of tourism and hospitality research.

"Last year, a little over 1 lakh foreign tourists visited Himachal. This included

visitors from Europe, Canada, the U.S., and Israel among other countries," says Bhanu Gupta, joint director at Himachal's Tourism Department.

This year, however, Dharamkot's narrow, stone-paved roads lined by tall pine trees look relatively deserted. The influx of Israeli travellers has been skewed and uneven, according to local hospitality players. Yet, over the years, the steady footfall of foreign tourists has helped the economy of this tiny village, even as the locals worry about the adverse impact of drug-laced raves in the forest.

Trailing peace

Jish says he and his wife are "here to relax" and will soon head out on their hired bike to Delhi and onward to Rajasthan. In Dharamkot, "There are different courses, like music sessions, yoga, drawing, and painting — there are so many options to unwind. In India, unlike Israel, there is more peace and nature, landscapes, and special people," he says as he grabs his belongings to move for his painting class in lower Dharamkot, run by residents largely through hired instructors. Charcoal painting and pencil sketching are popular among foreign tourists in this Himalayan village.

The 'Hummus Trail' gets its name from hummus — a West Asian food traditionally made from cooked chickpeas, tahini (sesame

Getting away from gunshots

For many young Israelis, Dharamkot in Himachal Pradesh offers an escape from the pressures of military service and conflict, but locals in the tranquil Himalayan retreat worry about drug use and rave culture



Many Israeli tourists come to Dharamkot to relax after completing their conscription terms. R.V. MOORTHY

paste), lemon juice, garlic, and olive oil. The trail has many cafés and restaurants catering to Israeli travellers. The route spans several places in the mighty mountains of the Himalayas, like Kasol, Old Manali, Rishikesh, and Ladakh. It stretches across Uttar Pradesh's Varanasi and Pushkar in Rajasthan, extending to South Goa, Gokarna and Hampi in Karnataka, and Vattakanal in Tamil Nadu.

Hodaya, 23, also from Israel, has come to Dharamkot with her friend, drawn

by the popularity of the 'Hummus Trail'.

"Most Israelis follow the Shvil Hummus (Hummus Trail) route in India and Nepal, as it has many cafés with Hebrew menus, Israeli music, and food. I have been in India for about two months now, travelling between Manali, Leh, and Dharamkot. It's relaxing here," says Hodaya, who is set to return to Israel in a couple of days. Asked how she feels about the ongoing West Asia conflict, she shrugs it off with a smile, saying, "I

am used to it, so I am not stressed anymore."

Monetising tourism

The stone walls across Dharamkot are dotted with posters in Hebrew, alongside English. In lower Dharamkot, more accessible by road than the upper areas, the bulletin boards outside cafés, restaurants, roadside stalls, and homesays on the market stretch, serve as a news feed for different events for the village's international community. There are wellness workshops, music and art

events, community activities, and notices for parties.

Narender Pathania, 54, who runs an eight-room guest house in Dharamkot, points out that the flow of Israeli travellers has been unsteady for the past three years. The first lull, he says, was in 2023. That year, on October 7, Hamas-led Palestinian armed groups crossed into southern Israel, killing more than 1,200 people.

The tourists, Pathania says, further dropped after the U.S.-Israel and Iran conflict broke out in February 2026. "Almost all of them had left when the war with Iran started. Now some have returned, but the flow is lower. All my rooms, which used to be packed during these days, are vacant. It eventually brings loss. Tourism is the primary livelihood for many in our village," he says.

Vivek Kumar hails from neighbouring Dharamshala, manages routine affairs at 'Dharamkot studio' that offers pottery and ceramic courses in Dharamkot. "Among the foreigners who come to us, Israelis make up the largest share. We have different courses ranging from five to 35 days. A minimum two-hour workshop is also available to experience the process of shaping wet clay into finished objects. Most of those who enrol with us are Israelis. In their country, these things are quite expensive, as I understand from speaking with them,"

he says.

Sanjeev Gandhi, chief adviser to the Hotel and Restaurant Association, Smart City, Dharamshala, who himself runs Hotel Gandhi's Paradise at Dharamkot, shares his experience on why Israelis are drawn to the town.

"Most Israelis come carrying the weight of war and stress. They come to forget. What they value most about Dharamshala is the silence," says Gandhi, recalling a number of them telling him that the biggest draw is that they don't hear gunshots.

Rage against the rave

The 'Hummus Trail', also notorious as the 'Hashish Trail', is a route taken for readily available cheap drugs, says the *Anatolia* paper. In June 2026, taking suo motu action, the Himachal Pradesh High Court directed the transfer of three senior officers, including the then Deputy Commissioner and Superintendent of Police of Kulul district, in connection with the alleged nexus between officials and organisers of big-scale rave parties in Kulul district.

Om Prakash Sharma, a former Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) officer, who handled several enforcement operations in Himachal, Punjab, and Jammu Kashmir while he worked with the NCB's Chandigarh zone from 2002 to 2007, asserts that cultivation of cannabis and opium in remote areas of Kulul district

and Mandi district of Himachal continues unabated. "The narcotics trade cannot survive unless there's support from the socio-political and administrative strata. Foreigners have been found involved in the illicit drug trade," he says. He adds that regular Himachali people get involved because of "local poverty" and "easy money".

"Rave parties in secluded forest areas are being organised in the name of tourism, which is not possible without the shelter of bigwigs and administrative machinery and local political patronage," he adds. Monika Pathania, former councillor of Dharamkot ward, which falls under Dharamshala Municipal Corporation, says, "People talk about rave parties happening here, but that's simply not true. Such things don't happen at all in the village. It could be happening in remote areas where police presence is minimal, but in Dharamkot and neighbouring Bhagsnag there are police check posts to keep a tab on unlawful activities."

Gandhi is worried that locals too are impacted by drugs. "We have been urging the locals and administration to create a joint team to tackle the drug menace," he says.

For many young Israelis like Jish, Dharamkot is an escape from war, a holiday of healing.

vikas.vasudeva@thehindu.co.in



UPASI TEA RESEARCH FOUNDATION CENTENARY CONFERENCE

UPASI, Glenview, Coonoor, The Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu



Hearty Welcome

Shri C. P. Radhakrishnan

Hon'ble Vice President of India

for inaugurating the
Conference Today

*Your gracious presence inspires us as we come together to
celebrate a century of research, innovation and sustainable
growth in the tea industry.*

The origins of organised tea research in South India trace to the early twentieth century, when planters' associations, responding to mounting challenges from pests, disease and declining yields, pressed provincial governments for dedicated scientific support.

United Planters' Association of Southern India (UPASI) formally established its Scientific Department in 1919, and in 1925 recruited Dr. W. S. Shaw as its first Tea Scientific Officer. Within months of his arrival, Dr. Shaw established the Tea Experimental Station at Nellakotta (Gudalur) in October 1926; the founding moment of what would become the UPASI Tea Research Foundation.

As the reach of the South Indian tea industry expanded, the research establishment grew and relocated to a more central location. Between 1961 and 1966, UPASI acquired land at Valparai, in the Anamallai Hills of Coimbatore district, and shifted its research headquarters there, where

the Headquarters of the Tea Research Foundation continues to operate today. A network of Regional Advisory Centres was subsequently established to bring research directly to planters across the tea-growing tracts of the three southern States located at Munnar (1968), Coonoor and Meppadi (1971), Gudalur (1980), and Koppa (1987), in addition to a substation at Vandiperiyar, Kerala (1964).

In 1999, in recognition of the need for a more structured and accountable administration of tea research, UPASI reconstituted its Tea Scientific division as a formally governed body; the UPASI Tea Research Foundation. Its Board of Trustees today includes nominees of UPASI's Executive Committee together with two representatives of the Ministry of Commerce & Industry, Government of India, and three representatives of the Tea Board of India, including its Chairman; reflecting the Foundation's standing as a public-private partnership in agricultural research.

The year 2026 marks one hundred years since the founding of the Tea Experimental Station at Gudalur; a century that spans the colonial establishment of scientific tea research in South India, its consolidation under an independent India in partnership with the Ministry of Commerce and Industry and the Tea Board, and its continuing role today in equipping the industry to

meet contemporary challenges of climate resilience, sustainability and international quality compliance.

UPASI TRF is marking this milestone through a Centenary Conference at Coonoor on 22 September 2026, bringing together planters, scientists and policymakers to commemorate the Foundation's legacy and to set its direction for the century ahead.

The UPASI tea scientific department, since its inception in 1926 has contributed significantly to the growth of the tea industry in south India. Its contributions in all spheres of research have been substantial and the major factor underlying this success has been the direct relationship between the scientists of the tea scientific department (now the Tea Research Foundation) and the members of the planting community. The higher production and productivity in south India are mainly due to the improved cultural

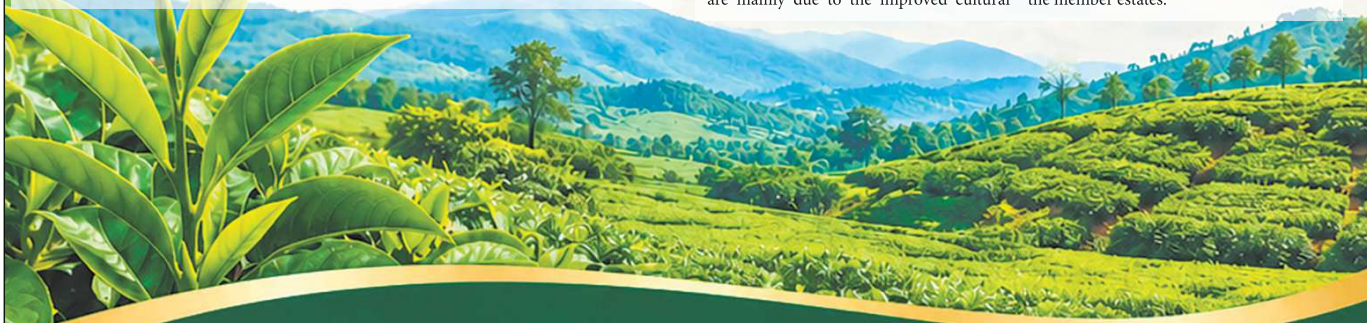
practices, which have resulted from the intensive research and extension efforts of the UPASI Tea Scientific Department during the span of last one hundred years in the areas of clonal selection and plant breeding, harvesting, manuring and plant protection. Progressive increase in productivity is the outcome of the advancement made in the lab to land programme, the effective transfer of technologies through various Regional Advisory Centres and positive perception of technologies and adoption by the member estates.

United Planters' Association of Southern India Tea Research Foundation

Research Headquarters: Tea Research Institute, Nirar Dam (PO), Valparai, Coimbatore (Dist.), Tamil Nadu - 642 127

Administrative office: Glenview, Coonoor, The Nilgiris, Tamil Nadu - 643 101

Website: www.upasitearesearch.org





Serious escalation

The new U.S. law on Russian oil imports carries more legal weight

The U.S. Russia Sanctions Act, now signed into law by President Donald Trump, and its resultant impending tariffs, present a new and substantially different escalation of tensions between the U.S. and India. The law provides to the U.S. President the authority to levy tariffs of up to 100% on countries such as India that import large quantities of Russian oil and gas. This is more serious than the penal tariffs that Mr. Trump had levied earlier. The escalation last year of reciprocal tariffs to 50% on India's import of Russian oil was based on an Executive Order, and could be rescinded through the same method. This latest Act has been passed by the U.S. Congress and so carries a higher order of legal permanence and authority. Mr. Trump will have to justify in writing to Congress any waiver he wants to provide. The 50% tariffs hit Indian exports to the U.S. hard, but the impact was somewhat mitigated by exporters sharing the cost with their American customers. That was, however, a financially devastating and unsustainable bid to retain customers. Sharing a 100% tariff will be impossible for India's largely micro, small and medium enterprises (MSME) exporters. The 100% tariffs are also over and above the 10% 'forced labour' tariffs and the 50% Section 232 tariffs on steel and aluminium. Indian exports to the U.S. will simply become too uncompetitive should these new tariffs come to pass. India has three options before it: cut Russian oil imports, retain those imports and bear the tariffs, or convince the U.S. to implement a low tariff using the "up to 100%" phrasing of the law.

Continuing with Russian oil imports and bearing the tariffs would be a significant blow to India's export ambitions and MSMEs. The U.S. is India's largest export destination, accounting for about 20% of its total goods exports. In any case, historical data have shown that India has usually complied with U.S. pressure to cut oil imports from particular countries, including from Russia, vocal claims of strategic autonomy aside. Finding other sources will be difficult. Russia accounted for more than 5% of India's oil imports as of July 2026, while supplies through the Strait of Hormuz remain constrained. India will have to chivy countries such as Oman to hasten their expansion of alternative ports. The price of oil remains well above \$100 a barrel, meaning finding favourable deals with new suppliers will be increasingly difficult. Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal will have much to do during his planned trip to the U.S. at the end of this month for the G-20 Trade Ministerial. There are still 30 days before the U.S. can levy its tariffs. India's ability to secure a low rate will be a true test of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's friendship with Mr. Trump.

Antidote to drugs

The government must tighten the monitoring of drug production

With the recent bust of a counterfeit medicine racket in Bengaluru, a public policy issue with broad ramifications for health care in the State has emerged. Centered around Bengaluru, relabelled or fake drugs, including cancer drugs, injections used in the ICU, were supplied to more than 90 hospitals and clinics across the State. The lid was blown off this elaborate scam after incidental raids, near Bidadi in Karnataka on August 18, found suspected fake drugs and expired drugs at a farmhouse which was an unlicensed unit. The consignment had a label value of ₹5 crore. Investigators said that the farmhouse was used in an illicit drug operation – involving the repackaging of fake and expired drugs as fresh consignments, with altered expiry dates, and as expensive, imported branded drugs – which were then sold at massive discounts. The State later formed a Special Investigation Team to trace the wider network. While exploring the distribution mechanism, investigators found that the network had been supplying these drugs to over 90 hospitals in the State, in cahoots with a pharmacy in Bengaluru, indicating that a network was thriving well before the bust. A few persons have been arrested and the police are on the tail of another who is not in the country at present. The impunity with which the scammers were operating is an indication of the unreliable security of the quality of drugs in the market. The biggest concern, however, is patient safety, given that these are drugs that can save lives and are marked out for time-sensitive usage. Also being examined are possible inter-State links, as investigators have launched a complete review of the supply chain. The illicit channels through which private hospitals bought and used these drugs, including possible complicity in the private hospital network, are under scrutiny.

With alarming regularity, issues to do with poor quality, spurious, fake or expired drugs hit the headlines in India. For a nation that zealously aspires to become the 'pharmacy of the world', India struggles to match its ambition with adequate and stringent monitoring and quality control systems. The question of drug quality is particularly significant as fake or spurious drugs can cause immediate adverse reactions, lead to severe disabilities, and even death. Recent incidents of contaminated cough syrups causing deaths, not only in India, but across the world, have further highlighted these woefully inadequate systems and consistently dented the pride of the "Make in India" campaign. Irrespective of whether India becomes the pharmacy of the world, there is a pressing need to make sure that drugs and medical supplies made in the country fulfil the highest quality standards.

When the first Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) was passed in 1976, a government of a different political hue was in power from the one that has now proposed the more fierce FCRA Amendment Bill, 2026. But the underlying political apprehensions were similar – the fear that foreign powers could destabilise the country by funding civil society organisations (non-governmental organisations or NGOs). In the present case, there is also an unstated fear of religious conversions by Christian and other religious minorities. The Bill is yet to be enacted because of strong reactions by the Opposition parties and several civil society groups, particularly Christian organisations.

The government claims that the flow of foreign funds into India's NGO sector operates as a vast, intricate and opaque web. Under the banners of development, human rights and social welfare, thousands of crores of unmonitored capital pour into the country every year. Much of this money deliberately bypasses state accounting mechanisms and finds its way into politically charged campaigns, highly selective local advocacy, and aggressive proselytisation and religious conversion networks.

Proposed legislation, the concerns

Under the proposed legislation, if an FCRA certificate is cancelled, surrendered or automatically lapses, foreign contributions and all assets created from them would vest in a government-appointed "designated authority". The organisation can recover the assets if registration is restored within the prescribed period. Permanent vesting will occur only if registration is not restored within that period. The Bill also provides for revision and an appeal to the District Judge.

If a fresh certificate is not obtained within the prescribed period, the assets could be sold or transferred to a government department, with the proceeds going to the Consolidated Fund of India. However, during the provisional-vesting period, restoration of registration results in return of assets and unused foreign contribution.

NGOs, especially Christian organisations, which the government says receive a larger proportion of the funds, among religious associations, are worried that the legislation may not be religion-neutral and that, ultimately, the real sufferers would be the beneficiaries served by such charitable organisations, which have established and operate numerous schools, hospitals, old-age care homes and similar institutions. As some leaders from the northeast and tribal areas have pointed out, such institutions are sometimes the largest or only providers of these services in many areas.

Already, the FCRA registrations of 22,496 NGOs



Pushpa Sundar

The author of several books on philanthropy, with the latest title being 'Giving with A Thousand Hands: The Changing Face of Indian Philanthropy'

have been cancelled since 2015, leaving about 14,466 active registered associations eligible to receive foreign contributions (Ministry of Home Affairs data, September 2026). In fact, the amounts received are larger than those in 2006-07 (₹12,289.6 crore from private international donors), the last year for which data were available when this writer wrote the book, *Foreign Aid for Indian NGOs: Problem or Solution?* (2010).

So why the protests? The fact is that different sources of funding have a differential impact on organisations and their effectiveness because, as the saying goes, "He who pays the piper calls the tune".

Though in total, the volume of foreign aid to NGOs is small compared with government budgets, and only a small proportion of NGOs receive such aid, it is highly valued because it is not only an alternative source of funding but also more flexible than government funding, with fewer restrictions on how it can be used. It is generally tailored to an NGO's needs through discussions between the NGO and the donor.

The book, *Foreign Aid for Indian NGOs*, which is based on desk research and interviews with several NGOs, large and small, suggests that while a few organisations felt that foreign aid had adverse consequences, such as encouraging the adoption of ideas and practices from abroad that were unsuited to Indian conditions, most felt that foreign funds had contributed to India's development and, in particular, to the growth of the voluntary sector. They had brought in new ideas, techniques, technologies and organisational improvements. In the absence of adequate government funding and private philanthropy, foreign aid had played a positive role.

Need for funding diversity

Today, however, given political events in neighbouring countries and elsewhere in the world, and without being privy to the secret sources of information that the government has about the destabilisation role played by foreign money, it is difficult to pass a definitive judgment on the need for and value of foreign aid today.

There can be no doubt that a vibrant and independent civil society is necessary for a healthy democracy and for preventing the abuse of unrestrained political power by any one section of society. Plural sources of funding are also necessary to ensure that civil society is not dependent on any one source.

But equally, one can question whether foreign funds are the only answer to the needs of civil society today. First, the voluntary sector is more developed now. Second, the situation regarding foreign aid itself has changed. Bona fide foreign donors are themselves moving away from giving

to India because of their own economic difficulties and the perception that India, which is aiming to become the world's third-largest economy, no longer needs aid from them.

Third, the domestic non-government funding environment has also improved. According to the Forbes 2026 list, there are 3,332 billionaires in the world, of whom 229 are in India, giving it the third-largest number after the United States and China. The amount they donate to philanthropy has also increased. According to the India Philanthropy Report by Bain & Company, private philanthropy was projected to reach ₹1.43 lakh crore (\$16 billion) in FY 2025. In addition, there is retail giving of about ₹37,000 crore annually.

The downside is that, according to the same report, demand is growing faster than supply, with projections indicating that the gap could reach ₹18 lakh crore (\$210 billion) by 2030.

Moreover, new philanthropists, especially entrepreneurs and technology leaders, are shifting away from traditional areas towards ecosystem building, scientific research, higher education and complex institutional support.

This is undoubtedly good news for social and economic change, but bad news for NGOs delivering traditional education, health and social welfare services.

A glimmer of hope for such NGOs is that, following the Companies Act, 2013, which made corporate social responsibility (CSR) spending compulsory for companies above a certain size, CSR spending by such listed companies was ₹22,563 crore in FY25, up 17.5% (latest CRISIL report).

Since many companies do not have the internal competency to undertake social development, they rely on NGOs as partners. Although many companies are moving into environmental and other emerging areas, many still find the traditional areas of health, education and rural development more meaningful.

A new opportunity

So if, in the ultimate analysis, the government does decide to limit foreign funding, the future need not be bleak if Indian domestic philanthropy steps up to fill the gap.

However, indigenous donors, and the government in particular, must become more responsive to the needs of NGOs, learn from foreign donors some of the practices that made their aid so sought after, and engage in more serious dialogue on funding practices, as distinct from development issues, to improve those practices and address the dissatisfaction on both sides. Ultimately, it is the innate generosity that is dormant in hundreds of dedicated Indians that will change the dynamics of development in India, not foreign aid, which at best can be the cherry on the cake.

India's real rate moment, the cost of delay

India is approaching an uncomfortable turning point in monetary policy. With the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) holding the repo rate at 5.25% while inflation rises, the real policy rate is steadily losing its cushion. Consumer price inflation rose to 4.82% in August, from 4.45% in July, marking the third consecutive month above the RBI's target of 4%. Food inflation is even higher at 5.95%. Core inflation has also risen to around 4.2%, suggesting that price pressures are broadening beyond food.

A view on the real interest rate is not obtained simply by subtracting yesterday's inflation from today's policy rate. Monetary policy operates through expected inflation. If the repo rate remains at 5.25% while inflation expectations move towards 5.25%, the ex-ante real policy rate becomes approximately zero. That is a very different monetary environment from the one in which the real policy rate is comfortably positive.

Closer to zero real rates

India is now much closer to that point than it appeared after the August policy. The RBI maintained a neutral stance, while projecting FY2026-27 inflation at around 5%. However, the latest inflation reading has moved beyond the RBI's projected average trajectory for the year: headline inflation is already 4.82%, while food inflation is 5.95%.

Therefore, if inflationary pressure maintains the current momentum and external pressure aggravates, India could soon find itself in a zero real interest rate environment.

The risks surrounding that trajectory are hardly trivial. The monsoon remains an important source of uncertainty. More importantly, India is confronting a potentially powerful external inflation shock. Renewed conflict in West Asia has disrupted shipping



Saumitra Bhaduri

Professor, Madras School of Economics

through the Strait of Hormuz and pushed Brent crude above \$100 a barrel, with prices approaching \$110. The combination of higher oil prices, a weaker rupee and elevated global commodity prices creates a substantially more difficult inflation environment.

Falling real rates are often thought to stimulate demand and credit when the economy is operating below capacity. However, when demand is already healthy, and the inflation shock originates from supply and expectations, the same mechanism can amplify rather than neutralise inflation.

Banking system trends

India's banking system makes the issue even more interesting because the zero real rate is not transmitted symmetrically to borrowers and savers. Bank credit growth stood at 19.1% year-on-year at the end of August and remains exceptionally strong.

Deposits, however, have also surged. Deposit growth reached 17.8% at the end of August, the fastest pace in a decade, partly because of the RBI's special FCNR(B) mobilisation scheme. The increase therefore needs careful interpretation: it does not necessarily indicate that domestic households have suddenly become more willing to hold conventional bank deposits. Instead, much of the increase reflects foreign currency inflows under the special scheme. The credit-deposit ratio was around 80.3% at the end of August.

India is consequently experiencing strong credit demand even as banks compete for stable domestic deposits. Households increasingly have alternatives to bank deposits, including mutual funds and equities. When inflation rises, the real return on conventional deposits becomes less attractive, giving savers a greater incentive to

move towards market-linked assets, gold or other inflation hedges. Empirical evidence from India underscores the importance of this channel. RBI research on the earlier inflation episode found that rising inflation and inflation expectations reduced the real return on household financial savings. During the high-inflation period from 2010 to 2013, real returns on savings instruments became negative and household financial savings weakened, while demand for gold increased substantially. The correlation between gold imports and household inflation expectations was estimated at 0.83 over the period studied.

Therefore, did the RBI miss an opportunity to react earlier? A central bank should not raise rates simply because oil prices have increased. Yet, it must consider the risk that temporary inflation becomes embedded in expectations, wages, prices and credit.

That risk now looks more real. Inflation has remained above 4% for three consecutive months, and August's 4.82% reading was accompanied by a rise in core inflation to around 4.2%, while the one-year OIS rate is around 6%, signalling expectations of some future tightening. At the same time, GDP growth is running at 7.8%, and bank credit is growing at 19.1%. Demand is hardly weak.

The issue is about timing

A 5.25% repo rate may therefore appear restrictive in nominal terms, but offers increasingly little restraint in real terms. The real issue, therefore, is timing. In monetary policy, timing is an instrument in itself. A timely 25-basis-point adjustment may ultimately cost less than a delayed 50-basis-point correction. Importantly, the direction is clear – inflation is moving toward the policy rate while growth and credit remain strong. Perhaps the time has come.

The Reserve Bank of India faces a shrinking real-rate cushion as inflation rises and demand remains strong

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Climate action

India's lower per-capita emissions and progress on renewable capacity are significant, but climate responsibility cannot be discussed only through present-day averages (Front page, September 20). India's rising energy demand, urbanisation and industrial growth require a credible transition strategy. Greater investment in green public transport, energy-efficient buildings, storage technologies and

decentralised renewable power can reduce emissions. In addition, developed countries should provide predictable climate finance and technology access. In the end, a practical approach should combine equity, accountability and measurable targets, rather than competing narratives. **A. Myilsami,** Coimbatore

The real test
A 'bloated' medal tally at

the Asian Games is fine, but it can also create an illusion of sporting progress when several events lack Olympic-level depth. The real test remains the Olympics, where India's performance has repeatedly exposed the gap between regional dominance and global competitiveness. Celebrate medals, certainly, but measure sporting progress by performance against the world's best. **Harsh Pawaria,** Rohtak, Haryana

Immersion and lakes

I wish to highlight the severe environmental toll after idol immersions in Bengaluru's water bodies. The annual immersion of thousands of idols made of plaster of Paris and painted with synthetic colours releases heavy metals such as lead and mercury into lakes. This can poison aquatic life, damage local flora and fauna, and introduce toxic substances into the human food chain through bioaccumulation,

posing serious health risks. Tradition and nature need not be in conflict. Citizens and organisers must consciously shift to natural clay idols and non-toxic colours to ensure that our celebrations preserve rather than pollute the environment. **Sowmya Devi Rammoan,** Bengaluru

Dumping festival idols into our local lakes is getting out of hand. These huge structures are covered in

toxic chemical paints and made of Plaster of Paris, which pollutes the water. If we want to save our shrinking lakes and water bodies, the government must completely ban chemical paints and non-biodegradable materials. Our celebrations should not end up destroying the environment. **Shreshya Bhardwaj,** Bengaluru

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Campaign to reduce the intake of salt

Salt, as an essential electrolyte, sits at the centre of human well-being, but being most prone to overuse and misuse, the condiment remains at the heart of illness as well. When Tamil Nadu Health Minister K.G. Arunraj took salt to the floor of the Assembly, he dragged it willy-nilly into public discourse. He announced plans to launch a multi-pronged mission to reduce salt intake, turning attention to the right quantities and forms that must be consumed. The Minister's speech made it clear that the government's plans were not merely about a dietary tweak, but instead, a recalibration of how well-being is perceived.



Ramya Kannan

the national average of 28.5%. There is a direct link between consuming excess salt and hypertension — consuming too much salt causes the body to retain extra water, which increases blood volume and puts higher pressure on the arteries walls, leading to clinical hypertension.

Action plan

The State government's plan is comprehensive. For the first time, a Statewide survey using urine samples will scientifically measure salt consumption. Salt will be gradually reduced in government-run kitchens, including the Nutritious Meal Programme, ICDS centres, government hospitals and hostels. The feasibility of introducing a low-sodium salt substitute will be examined. This will be backed by a State-wide awareness campaign on how to read labels on packages, tasting before adding salt, and using natural flavour enhancers. Researchers of a randomised, double-blind, controlled trial reported in the *American Journal of Clinical Nutrition* in 2021, wrote that replacing salt with a reduced-sodium, added-potassium salt substitute is an acceptable and effective dietary intervention for lowering systolic blood pressure in persons with hypertension in rural India.

The State also intends to step up its hypertension control activities through its community health outreach programme Makkalai Thedi Maruthuvam and other public health care institutions. People diagnosed with hypertension will receive systematic counselling and anti-hypertension drugs.

Cutting down salt is a simple change that can make a major difference to cardiovascular health — less salt today can mean lower blood pressure, fewer heart attacks, and fewer strokes tomorrow

There is evidence that such closely-monitored health interventions succeed.

The Sapiens Health Foundation has welcomed the new salt reduction campaign of the Tamil Nadu government. Its founder Rajan Ravichandran says, "This is a wonderful surprise, we have been knocking at many doors to bring in awareness of salt reduction in the public health sector. It can be very powerful in changing the way people consume salt. We just have to go back to 2005, where the campaign initiated by Graham MacGregor of the World Action on Salt, Sugar and Health, resulted in a reported 30% reduction of salt in bread, in the U.K."

G. Sengottuvelu, senior interventional cardiologist, Apollo Hospitals, explains further, "Excess salt is one of the most important and preventable contributors to high blood pressure, heart attack and stroke." His argument is that Indians' preference for salty food is largely an acquired habit, often beginning in childhood, and the palate can adapt when salt is gradually reduced. Cutting down salt is a simple change that can make a major difference to cardiovascular health — less salt today can mean lower blood pressure, fewer heart attacks, and fewer strokes tomorrow.

As Tamil Nadu rolls out its programme, hopefully with scientific vigour and cultural sensitivity, other States will do well to watch and emulate. If it is possible to cut down hypertension, cardiovascular disease, and kidney disease with adjusting the size of a single pinch, then, why not?

ramya.kannan@thehindu.co.in

Missing measure in India's magnet mission

Most Indians know the parable of several blind men trying to describe an elephant. One touches its trunk and believes it is a snake. Another feels its leg and insists it is a pillar. None is entirely wrong, yet none sees the whole animal.

India's strategy for advancing its cutting-edge technologies, aimed at becoming a global manufacturing leader, carries the risk of making a similar mistake. From EV motors and semiconductor to precision manufacturing machineries, at the heart of each lies an unassuming component: the high-performance permanent magnet. They serve as the silent operating system of industrial acceleration.

Magnets are not all the same. Ferrite, Alnico and Samarium-Cobalt magnets continue to serve important industrial applications. Yet Neodymium-Iron-Boron (NdFeB) magnets have become the backbone of energy transition and advanced manufacturing because no other commercially available permanent magnet combines comparable magnetic strength with such a high power-to-weight ratio. Recognising its importance, India has begun strengthening its critical minerals and rare earth element strategy through initiatives such as the National Critical Mineral Mission, overseas mineral acquisitions, expanded geological exploration, and PLI schemes.

However, China's tight export controls on rare-earth magnets and materials in April 2025 not only revealed the

Suvajit Banerjee

Fellow at the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER), New Delhi in the research vertical of Computable General Equilibrium Modelling and Policy Analysis. Views are personal

Sovini Mondal

Research Analyst at the research vertical of Computable General Equilibrium Modelling and Policy Analysis. Views are personal

Sanjib Pöh

Professor and Thematic Lead at the NCAER in the research vertical of Computable General Equilibrium Modelling and Policy Analysis. Views are personal

The strategic question is not simply whether India possesses rare-earth resources or whether imports from China can be reduced. The real policy challenge is understanding what happens in between

deep-seated vulnerabilities in global industrial value chains, but also the limits of our understanding. For India, the primary vulnerability does not stem from a shortage of critical minerals; rather, it lies in the absence of a comprehensive framework to pinpoint where strategic technological dependence is cultivated, accumulated and propagated throughout the permanent magnet value chain.

The journey of a magnet

Consider a simple example. India's Annual Survey of Industries estimates the domestic permanent magnet market at around ₹750 crore. Yet international trade statistics indicate import values several times larger than that entire reported market. The gap may reflect differences in statistical coverage, industrial classification or supply-chain accounting. Whatever the explanation, policymakers face a troubling reality: they cannot confidently explain where all these magnets enter the economy or how they move through it. In other words, parts of India's permanent magnet economy appear to exist without being fully visible in statistics.

Unlike other products, permanent magnets pass through a long technological journey. Geological exploration leads to mining. Mining feeds mineral processing. Processing enables chemical separation. Separation produces oxides, which are refined into metals, transformed into alloys, engineered into magnetic materials, and finally manufactured into finished magnets. Each stage demands different scientific knowledge, industrial capability and technological maturity. This is why

discussions on critical minerals frequently miss the real point. The strategic question is not simply whether India possesses rare-earth resources or whether imports from China can be reduced. The real policy challenge is understanding what happens in between.

Although India has developed capabilities across several stages of permanent magnet manufacturing, the country still lacks a systematic way of identifying where those capabilities are globally competitive, where critical gaps persist, and how dependence accumulates across production stages. India's statistical system provides only a partial picture of what is mined, imported, manufactured.

One way to bridge this gap is through an Integrated Techno-Economic Mapping (ITEM) framework which presently is a missing piece in India's industrial policy toolkit. Such a framework brings together information on engineering and economic measurement to show how a permanent magnet is built, from minerals in the ground to the finished products that power advanced manufacturing. More importantly, it would identify where industrial capability should be built, where technological partnerships become essential, and where domestic investment would yield the greatest strategic return. A country may secure mineral resources yet remain dependent if it lacks processing and manufacturing capabilities.

Bridging this measurement gap is not an academic exercise; it is an industrial imperative.

The paradox of self-reliance: India-China trade dynamics

While India is steadily building its manufacturing capabilities, that expansion remains deeply embedded in China-centric, import-dependent supply chains

DATA POINT**Surendar Singh**

After the bilateral meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in Delhi on September 12, India said the two leaders had underlined the need to address each other's concerns, including "structural trade imbalance and supply chain issues". This assumes significance as the widening trade deficit with China reveals a central paradox in India's ambitious Atmanirbhar Bharat mission to bolster domestic manufacturing and reduce dependence on global supply chains, with China as the implicit target.

India is steadily building its manufacturing and export capabilities. However, that expansion remains deeply embedded in China-centric, import-dependent supply chains — creating what may be called the "assembly trap" of self-reliance. Bilateral trade touched \$167.6 billion in 2025 but has become asymmetric, with imports from China rising much faster than India's exports (Chart 1).

Exports to China remained broadly stagnant between 2021 and 2025, while imports rose sharply by about 71% from \$87.5 billion to \$149.5 billion in the same period — highlighting persistent structural weaknesses in India's manufacturing and trade competitiveness. Nearly 70% of India's imports from China are intermediate goods and another 22% capital goods (Chart 2). This composition shows that the India-China trade deficit is not simply a consequence of Indian consumers buying Chinese finished products. It reflects deeper structural asymmetries in manufacturing capability and technological dependence, with India's reliance on Chinese supply chains extending into the manufacturing system as inputs, components and semi-processed goods.

The trends in India's top five import categories from China between 2021 and 2025 (Table 1) reveal that this reliance has deepened rather than diversified, despite initiatives such as Make in India and the Phased Manufacturing Programme (PMP). The combined value of the top five categories of imports rose from \$19 billion in 2021 to \$34.6 billion in 2025 — close to one-fourth of total imports from China, showing that India's import basket has become more concentrated in a few electronics-related categories. That telecom equipment, laptops and integrated circuits remain in the top five shows that India's electronics assembly is still structurally exposed to Chinese supply chains.

India has emerged as a major hub for mobile phone assembly, but the share of imported parts and components has risen sharply from 3.3% of the import basket in 2022 to 10.1% in 2025 (Chart 3) — revealing the contradiction in that success story: it has been shaped, at least so far, by downstream assembly rather than by a deep domestic component ecosystem.

Imports of sophisticated inputs and capital goods can facilitate industrial upgrading, but they become problematic when the dependence turns structurally persistent and domestic firms fail to build capability in semiconductors and other precision components. In order to resolve such structural and capability challenges, the focus must shift from incentivising assembly to building domestic technological capability, innovation, supplier networks and component ecosystems. The response should not be blanket restrictions but calibrated tariffs on parts and components, designed to nurture segments of domestic manufacturing value chains.

India should focus on enhancing access to global value chains while building domestic capabilities, so that critical technological dependencies do not harden into strategic vulnerabilities.

Structural asymmetry

The data for the charts were sourced from the World Integrated Trade Solution (WITS), developed by the World Bank in collaboration with the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD). Surendar Singh is an Associate Professor at O.P. Jindal Global University, Sonapat. Views expressed in this article are personal

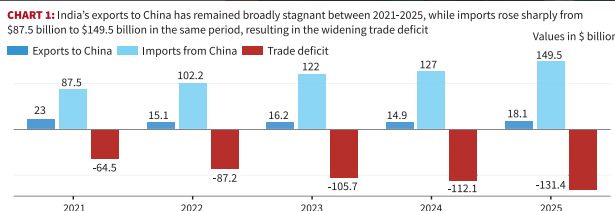


CHART 2: Intermediate and capital goods accounted for the major share of different categories of India's imports from China in 2025, as shown in this chart

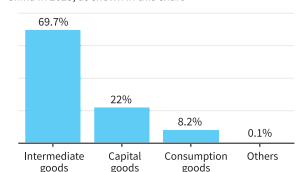


CHART 3: The share of India's imports of components, used for manufacturing mobile phones, from China has risen

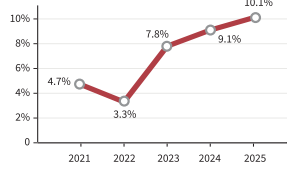


TABLE 1: India's import basket from China has been persistently concentrated in a few electronics-related categories rather than becoming more diversified over the years, indicating India's continued reliance on China for its manufacturing

India's top five imports from China (\$ billion)				
Year	Total imports (\$ bn)	Product groups	Top five imports (\$bn)	Share
2021	87.5	Laptops, telecom parts, LED/solar cells, ICs and transmission	19.0	21.7%
2022	102.2	Laptops, ICs, Telecom parts and Li-Ion batteries	19.0	18.6%
2023	122.0	Telecom parts, ICs, laptops, LED/solar cells and mobile phones	26.3	21.5%
2024	127.0	Telecom parts, laptops, ICs, LED/solar cells and mobile phones	29.5	23.3%
2025	149.5	Telecom parts, laptops, ICs, mobile phones and silver	34.6	23.2%

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 21, 1976

Toothpaste quality to be ensured

New Delhi, September 20: Leading manufacturers of toothpastes and other toilet goods agreed to-day to apply for certification by the Indian Standards Institution to ensure the quality of their products.

They also assured the Union Minister of State for Civil Supplies and Co-operation, Mr. A. C. George, that they would within a short time make their suggestions about a machinery which could deal with the pricing of these products.

Mr. George had a meeting here with senior functionaries of the All-India Soap and Toilettries Makers' Association, which represents manufacturers of toothpastes, soaps, cosmetics, perfumes, etc. in the organised sector.

Later, speaking to newsmen, Mr. George said there was a crisis of confidence among consumers over the claims made by manufacturers of toothpastes, etc. about the quality of their products.

The packaging of these products often created an optical illusion about their content. Misleading claims were made in advertisements and their prices were sometimes unduly high.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 21, 1926

Four persons attempting to cross Channel

Rugby, September 20: No less than 4 persons are or have been trying to swim the Channel to-day. They are all British. Miss Mona MacLellan and Mister Horace Carey entered the water at Cape Grisnez at 5:30 yesterday evening.

Colonel Freyberg who won the Victoria Cross made his third effort leaving Cape Grisnez at 5:30 this morning. Miss Marriott is starting from Cape Grisnez this evening.

Colonel Freyberg gave up his attempt when about seven miles from Dover owing to his position being unfavourable. He had been in water ten hours. This evening there was some excitement in Dover when a motor-boat accompanying Miss MacLellan and Horace Carey was sighted about a mile off the Dover Pier proceeding in a westerly direction. Apparently there was only one person in water but it was impossible to ascertain whether the swimmer was Miss MacLellan or Carey.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of Karnataka taluks to be declared drought-hit

200 More than 200 taluks across Karnataka are likely to be included in the drought-affected list as the government assesses them in phases based on prescribed criteria and ground-truthing, Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara said on Sunday. PTI

Ambedkar statues vandalised in Uttar Pradesh

151 Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday said 151 statues of B.R. Ambedkar were damaged across 72 districts of Uttar Pradesh during the BJP's rule, but only 14 arrests have been made so far. He alleged that the vandalism was done deliberately. PTI

Record-high average French diesel prices amid oil disruption

2.41 In €. French diesel prices hit a fresh record on Sunday, as the West Asia war disrupts oil supplies. The price per litre stood at €2.41 euros (\$2.76 dollars). Prices have been soaring across the world after the U.S. and Israel launched their war against Iran in February. PTI

Number of miners in Nigeria who died in detention

37 Thirty-seven young men were found dead inside a crowded cell in Minna, the capital of central Niger state, on Thursday. Survivors recounted being crammed in the cell with poor ventilation, and one said a substance that stung their throats and noses was sprayed into the cell. AFP

Number of people missing in Nepal flash floods

6,000 Search operations continued in Nepal on Sunday for around 6,000 people who are still unaccounted for nearly four weeks after the devastating flash floods that killed more than 1,400. PTI

Follow us [facebook.com/thehindu](https://www.facebook.com/thehindu) [X.com/the_hindu](https://twitter.com/the_hindu) [instagram.com/the_hindu](https://www.instagram.com/the_hindu)

The copyright stakes in the EU FTA

Draft India-EU FTAs copyright provisions could require changes to India's Copyright Act and weaken existing exceptions for students, archivists, Internet service providers; negotiators must seek to restore the WIPO Copyright Treaty to the National Treatment clause and preserve the country's digital copyright flexibilities

ECONOMIC NOTES

Zakir Thomas
Biswajit Dhar

Recently, the European Commission formally requested EU member states to approve the signing and conclusion of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement. Details of the commitments the two partners have accepted in the covered areas, including intellectual property (IP), have also been revealed. The draft IP Chapter includes detailed provisions on copyright that require close examination of their impact on India's digital policy landscape.

The structural asymmetry
Our assessment is that the provisions in the draft IP Chapter would necessitate amendments to India's Copyright Act, 1957, which is in conformity with international IP treaties including the WIPO Copyright Treaty (WCT) and the Trade-Related Aspects of Intellectual Property Rights (TRIPS) Agreement. Though the current provisions explicitly affirm the commitments of both parties to these IP treaties, they omit the WCT from the crucial National Treatment clause (Article 10.8).

It may be noted that the WCT was specifically adopted for the protection of works and the rights of their authors in the digital environment, particularly software and databases, while also providing for technological protection measures (TPMs). Excluding the WCT from the National Treatment provisions of the IP Chapter implies that the limitations on or exceptions to copyright for digital works that the WCT provides (Article 10) would henceforth be unavailable to India.

Limitations and exceptions under the FTA (Article 10.2) include a narrow "three-step test", borrowed from EU copyright statutes. If the extant exceptions in India's Copyright Act are not preserved, foreign rightsholders could challenge the exceptions for digital works available under Section 52 (or "fair dealing"), including transient or



GETTY IMAGES

incidental storage of a work or performance purely in the technical process of electronic transmission or communication to the public under Article 10.11 of the FTA, subjecting them to civil and criminal remedies.

The danger becomes more apparent when read alongside Footnote 1 of Article 10.8(i), which expands "protection" to cover enforcement measures against the circumvention of TPMs (Article 10.18) and Rights Management Information (Article 10.19). By including WCT's enforcement mandates among the binding obligations while excluding this treaty from the National Treatment exceptions, the draft IP Chapter abandons the WCT's principles, namely, balancing authors' rights with public interest exceptions in education and research, while providing a rigid enforcement mandate.

This structural imbalance directly threatens Section 65A of India's Copyright Act, 1957, which deals with TPMs. Section 65A(2) provides exceptions under which technological protection can be circumvented, particularly for the purposes permitted therein. Thus, if a student or researcher bypasses a digital lock to perform a lawful act protected under Section 52, no criminal liability attaches.

Chilling effect on classrooms, labs
The real-world consequences of this legal

shift will be borne by India's academic and educational institutions. Under Sections 52(i)(ab) and (ac) of the Copyright Act, engineering students and security researchers are legally permitted to observe, test, and reverse-engineer software to foster interoperability or uncover critical security vulnerabilities.

Yet, modern software is almost universally guarded by encryption and digital access controls.

Under a strict anti-circumvention regime, a computer science student breaking a digital lock to inspect code for system compatibility or security flaws could be transformed overnight into a legal offender. Similarly, public libraries and academic archives face unprecedented risks. In an era when historical documents, literature, and research are increasingly distributed in digital formats burdened by Digital Rights Management (DRM), librarians depend on format-shifting to archive out-of-print works and preserve fragile collections. A strict anti-circumvention rule would strip archivists of the legal right to bypass digital locks for preservation.

Furthermore, as higher education relies more on electronic materials, paywalls and DRM controls could effectively overwrite the public interest protections established by Indian courts in landmark rulings such as the DU Photocopy Case.

Threat to Internet service providers

Under India's Copyright Act (Sections 52(i)(b) and (c)), Internet service providers (ISPs) and digital intermediaries are shielded from liability for the temporary, transient copies created in RAM and server caches during routine data routing. The notice and takedown regime established under Rule 75 of the Copyright Rules, 2013 relies on these statutory safe harbours.

The FTA draft undermines this framework by granting rightsholders an exclusive, unqualified right over all "temporary or permanent" reproductions under Article 10.11(a), in contravention of the Agreed Statements to Article 8 and Article 10 of the WCT, which exempt transient network copies from copyright liability. Exclusion of the WCT from the National Treatment exception could, therefore, leave ISPs at risk of legal challenge, with EU rightsholders exposing Indian intermediaries to systemic liability.

By agreeing to the draft text, the negotiators seem to have gone beyond the Indian Parliament's mandate as reflected in the Copyright Act, 1957. Left uncorrected, this would oblige Parliament to remove the exceptions covering digital works in the Act, regardless of whether the user was engaging in legitimate, lawful research.

A call for recalibration

India's policy flexibilities must not be traded away in bilateral trade bargains. Our negotiators must insist on targeted revisions. They should press to re-insert the WCT into the National Treatment Clause. India's rise as a digital powerhouse rests on a foundation of open access to knowledge, robust educational inquiry, and independent technical research. While deepening trade ties with the EU is crucial, this must not be at the expense of our digital sovereignty or our students' right to learn. Negotiators must ensure the availability of statutory flexibilities in the copyright domain that keep Indian innovation alive.

(Zakir Thomas is the IPR Chair at National Law School of India University, Bengaluru and Biswajit Dhar was the IPR Chair Professor at JNU)

THE GIST

▼ The draft IP Chapter omits the WIPO Copyright Treaty from the National Treatment clause while retaining its enforcement mandates on technological protection measures and rights management information

▼ A strict anti-circumvention regime could expose students and security researchers to liability for bypassing digital locks while reverse-engineering software or examining security vulnerabilities

▼ Public libraries and academic archives could face restrictions on format-shifting digital works, while Internet service providers could face liability over temporary copies created during routine data routing

What does Tulu's new official language status mean?

How will the new status change the use of Tulu in administration? Is the Cabinet's decision enough?

Raviprasad Kamila

The story so far:

Karnataka government, in its Cabinet meeting held in Mangaluru on September 18, decided to accord the additional official (administrative) language status to Tulu, which is commonly spoken in Dakshina Kannada district, southern parts of Udipi district in Karnataka, and northern parts of Kasaragod district in Kerala. While making the announcement, Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar said the status will apply to administrative matters in the two districts. The government will release ₹82 lakh annually for translation, training and language usage purposes.

How will the decision help people?
B. Shivarama Shetty, former Project Director, Centre of Excellence for Studies

in Classical Kannada, Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL), Mysuru, said that elected representatives can speak in Tulu at gram sabhas of gram panchayats, taluk panchayats, and zilla panchayats meetings. It also applies to urban local body meetings such as city corporation council, city municipal council and town municipal council meetings. The government circulars and orders issued in the two districts should also contain Tulu. People can submit applications to government departments in Tulu. This will make officials who do not know Tulu depend on translations, translators, or learn the basics of Tulu.

When did the government move to grant official status to Tulu begin?
When the BJP government was in power, the then Minister for Kannada and Culture, V. Sunil Kumar, on January 30, 2023, formed a committee headed by M.

Mohan Alva, Chairman, Alva's Education Foundation, Moodbidri, Dakshina Kannada, to study and submit a report on declaring Tulu as the second official language of Karnataka.

The committee was asked to submit its report to the government in a week.

According to Mr. Kumar, the BJP government could not grant official language status to Tulu because the model code of conduct for the 2023 Assembly elections in Karnataka was declared on March 29, 2023, and the BJP lost power in the elections.

Later, the Congress government took over in Karnataka. It appointed a committee led by K. M. Gayatri, Director of Kannada and Culture, to study the procedures adopted by the Andhra Pradesh government to grant additional language status to Urdu.

This committee visited Andhra Pradesh on January 19 and 20, 2026, and studied

how Urdu is being used in administration. The committee submitted its report to the Karnataka government on March 4, against the backdrop of the move to declare Tulu as the additional official language.

Is the Cabinet's decision enough?

Article 345 of the Constitution allows each State legislature to choose one or more regional languages or Hindi as the official language for its official work. It says: "Subject to the provisions of articles 346 and 347, the Legislature of a State may by law adopt any one or more of the languages in use in the State or Hindi as the language or languages to be used for all or any of the official purposes of that State."

Section 2 of the Karnataka Official Language Act, 1963 states that Kannada is the official language.

Some law graduates say that if Karnataka is to implement the Cabinet's decision, it will have to amend the Karnataka Official Language Act to incorporate Tulu as an additional administrative language in Dakshina Kannada and Udipi districts. Once the amendment is approved by the appropriate authority, the Governor, the government will issue a notification, following which the Cabinet's decision will come into force. The governments of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana followed

the same procedure – amending their respective language laws – to declare Urdu as the second official language of their States.

How is this language introduced in academics?

Tulu is taught as the third optional language in schools, from Class 6 to Class 10, in Dakshina Kannada and Udipi districts. It was first introduced for Class 6 in the 2010-11 academic year. It is not being taught as a subject in pre-university and degree classes. Mangalore University introduced a two-year Tulu postgraduation programme in its erstwhile University Evening College (now closed down) in 2018-19. The programme was wound up from the academic year 2024-25, citing a lack of students in double digits who applied to join the programme.

Is it an independent language?

The Registrar General and Census Commissioner has recognised Tulu as an independent language of India ever since the department was established, and the Census Report gives statistics about Tulu speakers as a separate linguistic community.

It is treated as an important non-scheduled language of India. But it is not included in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution.

CACHE



GETTY IMAGES

How EU plans to keep children under 15 away from social media

EU is considering age-based rules that would restrict children's access to social media, video-sharing platforms, AI chatbots and online games; the proposal would place new responsibilities on technology companies, including age verification, safer recommendation systems, parental controls

John Xavier

The European Union is considering a major change to the way children access the internet, and it could affect everything from kids using Instagram, TikTok, YouTube, and various AI chatbots.

Under a proposal being prepared by the European Commission, per a report by Reuters, children under 15 could face restrictions on creating and using accounts across a wide range of digital services.

The EU's plan is part of the EU Kids Act, which is aimed at making digital services safe for children, and it comes at a time when governments around the world are grappling with growing concerns over how digital platforms affect children's well-being.

Social media platforms have come under increasing scrutiny over how they design their applications to be addictive and serve harmful content that is powered by recommendation algorithms.

Rather than imposing one rule on every child, the EU proposal would create different levels of access based on age.

Children aged 15 and above would be able to create their own accounts.

For children aged 13 and 14, access to social media and video-sharing platforms would require parents to get involved.

Parents could create introductory accounts for their children, with restrictions on contacts and time spent on the platforms.



For children between 3 and 12, accounts would be controlled entirely by parents. Their access would be limited to services considered suitable for children and required to meet stronger safety standards.

The proposal could potentially ban access to digital platforms for children under 3.

The exact rules could still change before the plan is formally presented and negotiated with EU governments and the European Parliament.

One of the more significant aspects of the proposal is its broad scope.

Beyond social platforms

The rules would not stop at platforms like Facebook, Instagram, TikTok and YouTube. They would also cover AI chatbots and online gaming platforms, bringing a much wider part of children's digital lives under the proposed framework.

The proposal is being framed based on the idea that children's internet use is no longer limited to scrolling through social feeds. They text AI chatbots, play games online, watch videos that are

Tech platforms have been arguing that they already have safeguards in place, as major social media applications have set a minimum sign-up age of 13; but critics have complained that age limits on paper are not enough

algorithmically recommended and chat with other users across numerous platforms.

The bloc's views on the overall digital ecosystem could make the path ahead for social platforms and consumer-facing AI applications a bit difficult, as they will have to take up new responsibilities.

More responsibilities for platforms

Platforms could be required to reduce features designed to encourage engagement and limit exposure to harmful recommendation feeds. They would also need to make it easier for children to report inappropriate content.

They will need to provide parents with stronger tools to control what their children see and how long they spend on their services.

Age verification could become an important requirement as social media and video-sharing platforms would need to verify a user's age when a new account is created.

Online gaming platforms would have to check age before allowing children to download games.

Apart from features that control the

use of these applications, tech companies could also be expected to pay for the system, as the bloc could propose a supervisory fee to fund regulatory enforcement and oversight.

Child and the digital ecosystem

The EU's proposal comes amid a growing clamour of voices wanting clear guardrails over a child's relationship with the digital ecosystem.

Tech platforms have been arguing that they already have safeguards in place, as major social media applications have set a minimum sign-up age of 13.

But critics have complained that age limits on paper are not enough if platforms cannot reliably determine how old their users actually are.

The EU's proposed approach would shift more of the responsibility onto technology companies, while giving parents greater control over younger children's online activities. This could mean fewer ways for children to sign up for popular social applications on their own.

Tech firms, on the other hand, will have to operate more carefully in the bloc as rules governing how they verify users, design their platforms and recommend content to younger audiences will structurally change.

This proposal still has a long way to go before becoming law. The European Commission will need to work with EU member states and the European Parliament, and the final rules could look different from the current draft.



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

Rakesh chose couch-surfing during his trip

My boss is proof that handsome is as handsome does

S. Upendran

"I don't know why Vrinda agreed to marry Ganpat. He's not very good looking and he..."

"True, but he's a wonderful person.

Very kind. You know what they say, 'handsome is as handsome does'."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"It's a roundabout way of saying good looks don't really matter. An individual's worth is determined by how he is with others – how he treats others."

"In other words, judge someone by his actions – what he does, and how he treats people. Looks can be deceiving."

"Whenever my grandmother caught my brother standing in front of the mirror for a long time, she used to say, 'Handsome is as handsome does.'"

"My boss is very good looking, but he's mean to all those who work under him. Handsome is as handsome does, I guess."

"One can also say 'pretty is as pretty does!' Priya might not be much to look at, but she's a very helpful person. You know what they say, pretty is as pretty does."

"That's true. Sheba tells me that Rakesh is taking a couple of months off."

"Yes, he's going to be doing some amount of travelling. He's spending a couple of months in Thailand and Vietnam."

"Either he has a lot of money or he knows a lot of people in those countries."

"Neither. He plans to do couch-surfing!"

"Couch-surfing?"

"The term was originally used for international travelling. When you do 'couch-surfing', you stay in a stranger's home for free."

"Really? That's a great way to travel."

"But you don't get the normal convenience or comfort of a hotel. You may be asked to sleep on a couch or the floor."

"Which explains why it's called 'couch-surfing', I guess."

"Exactly! Although you get to stay free of charge, you might be expected to help with the household chores."

"But how do you find a place to couch-surf?"

"Families which allow you to couch-surf advertise online. Rakesh's brother did a month of couch-surfing in Brazil last year."

"A family allowed him to stay with them for a month? That was..."

"When you couch-surf, you don't stay in a place for too long. You keep moving. Couch-surfing is something you probably do when you're young."

"I'm planning to visit Sri Lanka in December. Maybe I should couch-surf and see what the experience is like."

"Nowadays, the term has begun to be used when you're travelling within your own country and staying with people you may or may not know."

"So, you can couch-surf at your friend's place?"

"Your friend's place or a relative's."

Mohan and I are going to be spending a couple of weeks in Mumbai looking for a job. We'll be couch-surfing at the homes of our former classmates."

"Our flat wasn't ready. We were forced to couch-surf in several houses for over three weeks."

"Sounds good."

upendranky@gmail.com

THE DAILY QUIZ

Electronic band Depeche Mode released their first music video, 'Just Can't Get Enough', in 1981. Identify the following acclaimed electronic music videos from the hints below

Mohammed Hidayat

QUESTION 1

A man with a realistic dog's head and one leg in a cast wanders through New York City with a boombox.

QUESTION 2

A gymnast, played by Sofia Coppola, walks into a packed school sports hall to face a favoured rival.

QUESTION 3

A Frenchman wakes up, gets ready, and arrives in his customized car to compete in a car-audio

decibel contest.

QUESTION 4

A kid on a metro discovers that the music player in his hand can pause, rewind, and fast-forward the real world. A classic!

QUESTION 5

Shot in black and white, two men walk towards the camera as their T-shirts come alive with colourful typography.

QUESTION 6

A group of children with telekinetic powers escape a facility, test their abilities, and wait to join the outside world.



Visual Question:

Identify the music video from the screengrab shown. It won the Film Craft Grand Prix at Cannes Lions 2017. [ICONCLAST VIA YOUTUBE](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ICONCLAST)

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz:

1. It is well known that the Asian Games debuted in New Delhi in 1951. What is the only other time India has played host to the Games? **Ans: 1982 in New Delhi**

2. India is the fifth-most successful country at the Games. In which Games did it cross the 100-medal mark with 107? **Ans: Hangzhou 2023**

3. The most successful Indian athlete at the Games has 11 medals. Who and in which Games did the legend win four golds? **Ans: The peerless P.T. Usha and Seoul 1986**

4. Mohamed Anas Imran Beg, Declan Marshall Gonsalves and Quimcy Dsouza are representing India in which sport that is making its debut in 2026? **Ans: Teqball**

5. In which sport has India been dominant? **Ans: Kabaddi**

6. Which sport follows athletics for the most medals for India with 80 including 16 gold. **Ans: Shooting**

7. Who is set to become the first Indian sportsperson to feature at seven Asian Games? **Ans: Joshna Chinappa (squash)**

Visual: Name this swimmer. **Ans: Sachin Nag (100m freestyle)**

Early Birds: Prem Nath Tiwari | K.N. Viswanathan | Prem Raj P. | M. Suresh Kumar

Word of the day

Aggrandisement:

the act of increasing the wealth, prestige, power or scope of something

Synonyms: advancement, preferment, glorification, promotion

Usage: The award was not meant for personal aggrandisement.

Pronunciation:

newsh.live/aggrandisement

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to letters@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Text & Context'

From Page One

Tata Sons Board did not meet conditions: Trusts

Pointing out that the chairman's casting vote is available only where there is equality of votes at the overall board level, the Tata Trusts said it does not apply amongst Tata Trusts' nominee directors. "Whether the result of the vote was 4:1, or any other figure, is irrelevant. A condition is either met, or it is not. In this case the condition was not met," it stated.

No paralysis or deadlock?

"On the suggestion that a refusal of support [by nominee Director Mr. Tata] amounted to a deadlock which would paralyse the Company and that the Chairman of the meeting was therefore entitled to resolve the position by a casting vote, there was no paralysis and there was no deadlock," it reiterated.

"The Board put a question, and the AoA answered it in the negative. The exercise of a protective right conferred by a company's own constitution is not a deadlock; it is that constitution working as it was written to work," Tata Trusts said.

According to Tata Trusts, the resolution to reappoint Mr. Chandrasekaran as the chairman of Tata Sons, considered at the Board meeting on September 17, was not validly passed and has no legal effect.

"In the eyes of the law, it is void *ab initio* [from the beginning]," it reiterated.

Can't disown protection upheld by SC

Stating that the Articles of Association are not a convenience to be relied upon when they help and ignored when they don't, Tata Trusts said, "Tata Sons is not at liberty to take this position, because it has already taken the opposite one and won in the Supreme Court."

In the proceedings arising out of the removal of former Tata Sons chairman Cyrus Mistry, the affirmative voting rights of the Trusts' Nominee Directors under Articles 104B and 121 were squarely in issue, it said.

"The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal held them to be oppressive, and the complainants [Mistry & his SP Group Co] asked that they be deleted or confined. Tata Sons resisted that attempt. It defended these rights as a legitimate protection agreed between the shareholders, and it argued that far from being oppressive they were in truth the Trusts' entitlement as a majority shareholder," it pointed out.

In 2020, the Supreme Court of India had accepted Tata Sons' case and set aside the finding that these Articles were oppressive.

"The Company cannot now disown the protection it went to the Supreme Court to preserve. They are either in the Articles or they are not. Tata Sons has already told the highest court in the country that they are," it said.

No corporate governance gap?

"It is unfortunate that the Chairman [Mr. Chandrasekaran] of Tata Sons, a Company renowned for setting high standards of corporate governance, is contending reappointment on such an untenable interpretation of the Articles," it stated.

To the suggestion that listing will bring enhanced corporate governance, Tata Trusts said the argument of a governance gap does not exist. "Pulling apart a hundred-year-old structure to fill an imaginary gap is taking a sledgehammer to crack a nut," it said. "Independently of listing, Tata Sons has for years chosen to hold itself to the standards of a public company. Its own AoA contain provisions applicable to public companies, including the appointment of independent directors, the constitution of an audit committee and a nomination and remuneration committee, provisions governing related party transactions and the retirement of directors by rotation, together with a code of conduct for the prevention of insider trading," Tata Trusts noted.

Late economist, top poll official on SIR notice list

Besides Padma awardee Bibek Debroy and Election Commissioner Sukhbir Singh Sandhu, the names of Manish Sisodia, L.K. Advani, and S. Jaishankar too have been identified for notices by EC

Suruchi Kumari
NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, senior Bharatiya Janata Party leader L.K. Advani, Election Commissioner Sukhbir Singh Sandhu, and former Delhi Deputy Chief Minister Manish Sisodia were among several prominent names on Delhi's draft electoral roll to be identified for notices either for "logical discrepancies" flagged by the Election Commission's (EC's) software or under the "no mapping" category.

Economist and Padma awardee Bibek Debroy, who died in November 2024, also figures in Delhi's draft roll and has been flagged for "no mapping" with the previous special intensive revision (SIR) roll.

Notices are being generated to verify documents in cases of logical discrepancies in electors' records and to establish eligibility in cases of "no mapping". A list of those for whom notices were generated was published on Friday. It was reported on Saturday that Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, former Chief Minister



A voter in Delhi Cantonment constituency, Sukhbir Singh Sandhu's name was flagged over 'self-name mismatch'. PTI

Arvind Kejriwal, and former Union Ministers Kapil Sibal and Subramanian Swamy were among those on the list.

Debroy, who had served as chairman of the Prime Minister's Economic Advisory Council and was 69 when he passed away, is listed as a 70-year-old elector in the Delhi Cantonment Assembly constituency in the draft electoral roll published on August 31, *The Hindu* has found. He has further been included in the list of 33.1 lakh electors against whom notices have been issued. A notice was generated against his name because his record is unmatched to the previous SIR roll.

Also in the unmatched category were Mr. Advani,

his daughter Pratibha Advani, and daughter-in-law Geetika Advani.

A voter in Delhi Cantonment constituency, Election Commissioner Mr. Sandhu's name was flagged for the "self-name mismatch" discrepancy, which means a mismatch between the name given during the current SIR process and the previous roll.

The electoral registration officer (ERO) of the constituency later said in a press note that Mr. Sandhu's name had been validated for inclusion in the final electoral roll after "documents, facts, and details" were verified.

Notices were also generated for two former Chief Election Commissioners (CEC) of India. Sushil

Chandra and wife Neelu Chandra have been flagged for "no mapping with previous SIR".

The same reason was also given for former CEC Arun Goel's notice. Mr. Chandra served as 24th CEC from 2021 to 2022, and Mr. Goel served from 2022 till he resigned from the role ahead of the general elections in 2024.

Mr. Jaishankar and his wife, Kyoko Somekawa Jaishankar, have also been flagged for notice for "no mapping" with the last SIR. For the same reason, former BJP IT cell head Amit Malviya is also in the list, while "self name mismatch" has been flagged in the case of his wife, Gauri Malviya.

Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri's name was also in the list under the "no mapping" category.

In the Jangpura constituency, sociologist and social psychologist Ashis Nandy, senior advocates Indra Jaising and Anand Grover, and political communications consultant Dilip Cheria were all marked "unmapped with Last SIR". Journalist Sheela Bhatt was flagged for a "self-name mismatch" and senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi for no mapping.

High SIR deletions point to structural flaws, says Congress

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Sunday alleged that the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls was an assault on the Constitution, with party general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh citing data on deletions during the three phases of the exercise conducted so far.

Mr. Ramesh said in a statement that with the SIR process, the state had abdicated its responsibility and shifted the burden onto citizens to produce documents "it may never have provided them".

He said the Election Commission began the first phase of SIR in June 2025 in Bihar, followed by the second phase in November 2025 across nine States and three Union Territories. The two phases resulted in the deletion of 7.8 crore names. "The deletion rate as a proportion of the pre-SIR electoral roll works out to 13%," he said.

Mr. Ramesh said data on 12 States and two Union Territories showed that 6.18 crore names had been deleted from a total of 36.06 crore voters. "The deletion rate works out to over 17%," he said.

Mr. Ramesh added that another 15% of voters are at risk of deletion, as 5.43



Jairam Ramesh

crore voters had been issued notices seeking additional documentation to retain their names on the electoral rolls. "This is an unusually high proportion that reflects structural flaws in the entire SIR process. After such a large round of deletion, how can there still be so many additional voters who need to be verified?" he asked.

He said 32% (or about one in three voters) have either had their names deleted or face the risk of deletion.

Citing State-wise data, he said 53.73% of voters face the risk of deletion in Delhi, 52.58% in Chandigarh, 39.57% in Jharkhand, 35.36% in Uttarakhand, 35.36% in Meghalaya, 33.88% in Maharashtra, 48.90% in Telangana, 27.6% in Karnataka, 37.5% in Haryana, 23.67% in Odisha, 21.17% in Andhra Pradesh and 15.23% in Punjab.

AIUDF chief Ajmal is Assam CM's '108' service, says Gogoi

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assam Congress president and Jorhat MP Gaurav Gogoi on Sunday said All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF) chief Mohammed Badruddin Ajmal was contesting the Nagaon seat to benefit the BJP. He is Himanta Biswa Sarma's '108', Mr. Gogoi said while campaigning for Congress candidate Sibamoni Bora. He claimed that the AIUDF chief nominated himself because of Ms. Bora's strength, as part of the BJP's strategy to counter the Congress in minority-dominated constituencies.

The three-cornered contest also features the BJP's bureaucrat-turned-politician Devashish Sharma.

The bypoll, to be held on October 6, became necessary after Pradyut Bordoloi,

who won the constituency for the second time in 2024, quit the Congress and joined the BJP. He then contested and won the Dispur Assembly seat for the BJP in April 2026.

"Badruddin Ajmal is contesting the Nagaon seat to benefit the BJP. He is Himanta Biswa Sarma's '108', Mr. Gogoi said while campaigning for Congress candidate Sibamoni Bora. He claimed that the AIUDF chief nominated himself because of Ms. Bora's strength, as part of the BJP's strategy to counter the Congress in minority-dominated constituencies.

The three-cornered contest also features the BJP's bureaucrat-turned-politician Devashish Sharma.

Protest against the UGC's draft caste discrimination regulations called off

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Kshatriya Karni Sena and coalitions of "Savarna" groups called off their Sunday protest demanding the complete rollback of the 2026 UGC caste discrimination draft regulations, hours after Union Ministers J.P. Nadda and Jitendra Singh met delegates in New Delhi the night before.

Mr. Nadda said that discussions were held in a "cordial atmosphere" and that the "government will give due consideration to their demands". While announcing that the protest scheduled for Sunday was being called off, Raj Shekhawat, the national president of the Kshatriya Karni



Union Minister J.P. Nadda

Sena, added that the government had "proposed talks" and called the Saturday meeting at Mr. Nadda's residence "a significant achievement of our collective endeavours".

Mr. Shekhawat, along with a coalition of "Savarna" outfits, was scheduled

to lead a *mahapanchayat* protest at New Delhi's Jantar Mantar on Sunday. Their demands centred on the complete rollback of the UGC's 2026 caste-equity draft regulations, notified in January and stayed by the Supreme Court shortly after protests in several campuses in north India.

The Union government's decision to engage with the delegation led by Mr. Shekhawat came on the heels of the alleged suicide of a Dalit student at IIT Bombay amid allegations of caste discrimination. The incident has further fuelled the ongoing debate on the UGC draft regulations.

During the meeting on Saturday, about which Mr.

Nadda made a statement on social media at 2 a.m., the government sought three weeks' time to look into the demands raised by these groups and "conduct a detailed study". Mr. Nadda, in his statement, said that the government had agreed to meet with the delegation again in three weeks' time.

In his statement after the meeting with the Ministers, Mr. Shekhawat said, "Talks with the government have already begun on all the major demands for which this *mahapanchayat* was proposed, and the government has taken it seriously. We hope that the upcoming talks will yield concrete and positive decisions toward resolving all these discrepancies."

Protests over 'detention' of 7 Kuki villagers in Manipur

Press Trust of India
IMPHAL/KANGPOKEI

Violent protests erupted in Manipur's Kangpokpi district over the alleged detention of seven Kuki villagers by security forces, with agitators blocking roads and pelting stones at government vehicles, officials said on Sunday.

The protests continued from 10 p.m. on Saturday till midnight in Moring and nearby areas, during which agitators allegedly burnt tyres on roads and pelted stones at government vehicles, they said.

Protesters claimed seven villagers were detained by security forces without being given a reason.

Security forces fired several rounds of tear gas shells to disperse the protesters, who also allegedly dug up portions of NH-2.

Japan Air Force chief flies in Tejas jet, hails progress in defence partnership

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh, Chief of the Air Staff, said on Sunday that the Tejas sortie flown by Japan Air Self-Defense Force (JASDF) Chief of Staff General Takehiro Morita was a "very clear example" of the "faith and trust" on the "homegrown aircraft".

"The defence aviation industry and R&D are now set to hit much higher heights," he said.

The chiefs of the Indian Air Force (IAF) and the JASDF flew together in a Tejas formation in Jodhpur, underscoring the growing operational cooperation between the two air forces amid the expanding India-Japan defence partnership.

According to the IAF, Air Chief Marshal Singh led the formation in a fighter air



Air Chief Marshal Amar Preet Singh and JASDF Chief of Staff General Takehiro Morita board Tejas jets in Jodhpur on Sunday. PTI

craft, while General Morita flew in a trainer aircraft with Group Captain I. Samrat, Commanding Officer of the Tejas squadron, as the Captain.

Air Chief Marshal Singh said the India-Japan air partnership was based on "mutual respect, professional trust, and shared commitment to peace and stability". He described

the synergy between the two air forces as *kizuna*, the Japanese word for enduring bonds forged through trust and support.

General Morita described his Tejas sortie as a "powerful symbol of trust, confidence, and friendship" and said the bilateral engagement had moved beyond exercises aimed merely at refining tactical

capabilities. He said increasingly sophisticated training was strengthening the two air forces to contribute to regional peace and stability and pointed to cooperation across exercises, leadership interactions, subject-matter exchanges, and potentially the space domain.

The sortie was part of the second edition of the bilateral air exercise Veer Guardian 2026, which is being held at Air Force Station, Jodhpur, from September 9 to 22. It provided General Morita the opportunity to experience the indigenous Light Combat Aircraft Tejas and its systems.

The IAF is participating in the exercise with Tejas, Su-30MKI and Rafale fighters, while the JASDF has brought F-2A fighters. For the first time, JASDF fighter aircraft have operated from Indian soil.

Northeast's largest power project initiated in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday laid the foundation stone for the Adani Group's 3,200 megawatt Ultra-Supercritical Thermal Power Plant at Chapar in Dhubri district of Assam.

"Assam is fast emerging as the region's energy hub, with several mega energy projects in the pipeline. The 3,200 MW Chapar project is a proud outcome of the confidence generated by the Advantage Assam Investor Summit 2.0," the Chief Minister said.

The ₹48,000-crore project, handled by Adani Power Limited, will be the largest power plant in the northeastern region.

"This project will be one of the largest single investments ever made in Assam. Besides providing



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma during the launch of the thermal power plant at Chapar in Dhubri district. X/@HIMANTABISWA

massive employment opportunities, the State will also benefit through increased economic activity and SGST (State Goods and Services Tax) revenues, and local industries and enterprises will have opportunities to participate in the emerging ecosystem," he said.

Several families, mostly migrant Muslims, were evicted for the project. Jeet Adani, Adani Group

director, said the Chapar plant is part of a ₹63,000-crore power investment in Assam, with commissioning in phases from December 2030. The other projects include two pumped storage plants with a combined capacity of 2,700 MW.

"The project will also create jobs and open up opportunities for local contractors, suppliers and businesses," he added.

'Keen to explore ways to reset, renew Indo-Nepal ties'

Nepal Finance Minister says old era of jingoism and equating Nepali nationalism with anti-Indianism is over; during his visit to Delhi for meetings post the August floods, he pushes for revising trade treaty and connectivity plans; the economist says the Balen Shah government has spoken about some big signature projects or forms of assistance which can be adapted to the reconstruction needs

INTERVIEW

Swarnim Wagle

Suhasini Haidar

A month after floods wrecked areas in Nepal, its new government is intensifying efforts for reconstruction support. Nepal's Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle, an economist and former UNDP official, made his first visit abroad to Delhi to discuss plans with the Centre, and will soon travel to meetings of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the International Monetary Fund (IMF), and the World Bank to seek support for an estimated \$5-billion recovery project. Mr. Wagle said the new Balen Shah government wants a "reset" with India, and a revision of old trade and connectivity projects, including pushing for long-delayed over-flight rights for Nepal airports. Edited excerpts:

What is your estimate of the losses to Nepal from the Bhotekoshi floods?

Relying on government sources, the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) has estimated an early figure of about \$1.8 billion of direct damages and around \$900 million of losses, but all that's at replacement value. However, we're not going to simply replace what existed before, but rebuild for resilience in the future, and that's going to be more costly. We're estimating 4.7 to 5 billion dollars of reconstruction needs over the next three to five years.

How can India help? What specifically did you discuss during your visit to Delhi about projects that India can be involved in?

India has been very supportive, very proactive even in reaching out to us and we are keen to explore ways we can reset and re-

new Indo-Nepal ties. We have talked about some big signature projects or forms of assistance, which I think can be adapted to the reconstruction needs. After the 2015 earthquake, India had given us about \$250 million of grant assistance and \$750 million of LOC (line of credit). Now, some LOCs would need to go into the rehabilitation of our energy infrastructure.

Publicly built hydropower plants, transmission lines, sub-stations would ideally be addressed through concessional credit. But projects like roads and bridges and even public housing, I think would benefit from grant-based assistance. We leave it to the Government of India to organise their package in a way they feel appropriate.

Nepal's Foreign Minister had also said that big climate polluters India, China, and the U.S. bear some of the responsibility for this flooding, and that they owe Nepal reparations.



SEW KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Would you agree?

At this point in time, I think that line of thinking is rather unhelpful for us and for countries that have generously stepped in to help. However, some of these issues will come up at CoP conferences, including the next one in Turkey (November). We need to look at this event scientifically. The World Weather Attribution Group has concluded that climate change contributed to the thaw of the permafrost and to glacial

thinning. All sorts of global warming effects are visible in the Himalayas – permafrost, the mud, the mountain wall that was held together is now just cracking up.

As ties now improve, when do you expect PM Balen Shah will visit India?

I think Prime Minister Balen's visit to India will happen well before the end of the year. And this will be his first bilateral visit

abroad. He is planning to make a quick trip to the United Nations (next week), and will address the UN General Assembly on the 24th and return immediately. The only thing on his schedule right now is a courtesy call on the UN Secretary-General. His formal bilateral engagements will begin with India.

RSP (Rastriya Swatantra Party) leaders have spoken of a reset with India, and promised a relationship without any "old baggage". Does this mean the boundary dispute will not be an issue?

We don't carry much of the baggage [of the past]. It's not that we're going to shy away from some issues that might be uncomfortable to discuss, but we'll do it in a constructive way. The old era of jingoism and equating Nepali nationalism with anti-Indianism is over. We reject that. We also have to update the trade treaty, and that is an issue I

have taken up with both (External Affairs Minister) Jaishankar and (Finance Minister) Sitharaman.

I think it's incumbent upon us to seek that partnership to integrate with the Indian supply chain and for that you need big connectivity but thin borders. This is the Southeast Asian model that we have not emulated in South Asia yet.

On air connectivity, did you get any assurances from the Indian government? It has been several years since Nepal requested overflight for airports in Bhairahawa and Pokhara.

There's a bilateral mechanism on this issue which has been reactivated and it's going to meet very soon. And this time it's going to include defence officials as well. [Allowing overflight] will help Indian airlines too as it will reduce flight time, airfares and increase trade and tourism... There may

be some sensitivities on the Bhairahawa airport route because of Gorakhpur airbase, but that has to be seen with the new possibilities this will open up for India.

How would your government navigate issues that India has with Chinese-funded and built projects, like in hydropower?

India hasn't said don't involve the Chinese in any sector... just in sectors where India is procuring electricity. That's what we've been communicated. It used to be vague and now it's explicit which is helpful that this is the clear line and we can plan accordingly. I do believe that the media has a role in making some of the figures more transparent and analysing the trends. I did sense an element of paranoia in the way China-related stories are covered in the region.

(For full interview, go to: newsthe.live/waglenepal)

Trump's tariff decision can hurt energy security, trade, economy of India: Cong.

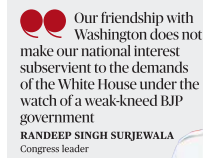
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress has termed United States President Donald Trump's decision to impose 100% tariffs on countries buying Russian oil as an unjustified action, warning that the move has serious implication for India's energy security, economy, and trade.

Congress Working Committee member and former Union Commerce Minister Anand Sharma and Congress general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala warned, in separate statements on Sunday, against "surrendering" to U.S. dictates, stressing that it is the Centre's sovereign duty to secure affordable energy for 140 crore people.

Mr. Trump's decision to sign the Lindsay Graham Bill into an Act that empowers him to impose 100% tariffs on countries buying Russian oil is a matter of grave concern, Mr. Sharma said.

"India is a major importer of Russian crude oil accounting for over half of crude petroleum imports this year, as the U.S. Israel attack on Iran and the West Asia conflict caused a serious disruption of oil and



Our friendship with Washington does not make our national interest subservient to the demands of the White House under the watch of a weak-kneed BJP government

gas supply globally and a sharp rise in petroleum and gas prices," he said.

"It is ironic that the U.S. itself is annually importing uranium and fertilizers valued at over \$4 billion. These have been carefully kept out of the ambit of the Graham Act. This is hypocrisy and double standards," he said, adding that the arbitrary targeting of strategic partner countries, including India, is unjustified, unacceptable, and condemnable.

'Abject capitulation'

Mr. Surjewala said that India is a sovereign republic with the right to buy energy from any nation that meets India's national interests and at a price its people can afford.

"Our friendship with Washington does not make our national interest subservient to the demands of

the White House under the watch of a weak-kneed BJP government. Securing affordable energy for 140 crore people is our sovereign duty," he said.

He added the sad story today was the "abject capitulation" by the Modi-led government, at the cost of the Indian economy.

"After 12 years of 'Vishwaguru' rhetoric, the Modi government has failed to build the counter-leverage needed to protect India from external economic pressure, nor does it show the courage to stand on equal ground and stand for our people and the nation," Mr. Surjewala said.

He added that while private refiners captured billions from discounted Russian crude, the government had left an \$86.5 billion export economy exposed to Washington's coercion.

BJP leaders criticise mimicry of Modi at Rahul's Indore event

Mehul Malpani
BHOPLAL

A political row erupted in Madhya Pradesh on Sunday, as BJP leaders slammed Congress leader Rahul Gandhi for featuring the mimicry of Prime Minister Narendra Modi by stand-up comedian Pulkit Mani at a student interaction event in Indore.

Mr. Gandhi, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, could be seen laughing during the performance by Mr. Mani at his *Chhatron Ki Goonj* event. In the act, Mr. Mani appeared to be mimicking Mr. Modi's interactions with foreign leaders and others. While Mr. Mani did not name the Prime Minister in his act, Mr. Gandhi said, "How are you, Modi ji?", while hugging him.

Another part of the act, where Mr. Mani appeared to be mocking the Prime Minister for asking for a chair for an elderly woman at a rally, took the most heat. Similar performances by the comedian have previously gone viral on social media.

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav shared a clip of the act and said that Mr. Gandhi's attitude was "extremely

Extremely shameful, misleading youth, says M.P. CM; cheap political theatre, says Union Minister

shameful". "This irresponsible attitude of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi is extremely shameful, condemnable, and unbecoming. By insulting the honour of our country's culture and mothers, he has encouraged leading the youth's future in the wrong direction," he wrote on X, late on Saturday.

The national working president of the Rashtriya Janata Dal, said Mr. Nabin, who is from Bihar, could not even get Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to visit the flood-hit State.

He said the decision of several NDA leaders, including Mr. Choudhary and Mr. Nabin, to donate their monthly salaries towards flood relief was just "drama to divert attention".

"Have the Prime Minister and Mr. Shah donated their salaries? How much money did all the NDA MLAs and MPs donate? Not more than ₹3 crore to the Chief Minister's Relief Fund. More than this, the

Tejashwi flays Bihar's flood relief efforts, says money wasted on PM's birthday

Amit Bheelari
PATNA

Leader of Opposition in the Bihar Assembly Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday criticised the ruling National Democratic Alliance government over flood relief efforts in the State and the money spent on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday celebrations. He also called Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and Bharatiya Janata Party national president Nitin Nabin "rubber stamps".

Mr. Yadav, who is also the national working president of the Rashtriya Janata Dal, said Mr. Nabin, who is from Bihar, could not even get Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to visit the flood-hit State. He said the decision of several NDA leaders, including Mr. Choudhary and Mr. Nabin, to donate their monthly salaries towards flood relief was just "drama to divert attention".

"Have the Prime Minister and Mr. Shah donated their salaries? How much money did all the NDA MLAs and MPs donate? Not more than ₹3 crore to the Chief Minister's Relief Fund. More than this, the



Hitting out: RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav addressing a press conference at his official residence in Patna on Sunday. PTI

NDA leaders wasted public money by lighting diya on the birthday of Mr. Modi. The Bihar CM and Mr. Nabin are just rubber stamps of Mr. Modi," Mr. Yadav said. He termed the lighting of lamps as being akin to rubbing salt on the wounds of flood victims, and asked whether NDA leaders' contribution of "₹2 crore-₹3 crore" was sufficient for the "50 lakh people affected by the flood".

Drought woes

Mr. Yadav pointed out that over the past 28 days, Bihar has been grappling not only with floods, but also drought. "The State has received less than 35% of its normal rainfall. Due to the severe drought, crops across lakhs of hectares of

land are being destroyed. Lakhs of farmers are unable to even recover their input costs. The government has not yet even assessed the drought situation and farmers are facing a livelihood crisis," he said. He claimed that a handful of community kitchens and relief camps were set up as a token gesture and that they were now shut due to a lack of funds.

He asked why Bihar was not assisted through the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund. "The number of people affected by floods in Bihar exceeds the total combined population of several other States... Yet, the Home Minister and the Prime Minister show no concern for Bihar. Is this not discrimination against Bihar?" he said.

Kurmis will be kept outside the ambit of UCC, says Suvendu

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday said the Kurmi community would be kept outside the ambit of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC).

He also announced that cases registered against members of the community during protests under the previous Trinamool Congress government would be withdrawn.

The Kurmis are a prominent community in the State's Jangalmahal region. They are currently categorised as Other Backward

Class and have been demanding the status of Scheduled Tribe (ST). They have also been seeking the inclusion of the Kurmali language in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution.

'Push for recognition'

Mr. Adhikari promised to push for constitutional recognition of the Kurmali and Rajbanshi languages.

The West Bengal government has said it would submit a "Further Common Justification Report" to the Centre to support the inclusion of the Kurmi community in the ST list.

**BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED**
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmasiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru-560052.

No. DGM-1/BSWML/Tend/17/2026-27
Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (Only Through GOK KPPP Portal only) **Call-3**
The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl No	Name of the Work	Amount put to tender per annum (Rs.in Lakhs)	EMD (In Rs)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Malleshwaram division (Package-10) Call-3	1,796.89	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.16,97,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /Scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

(1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal: **22.09.2026** (2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting: **25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office.** (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : **05.10.2026 before 17:00hrs.** (5) Opening of Technical Bid: **06.10.2026 after 17:30hrs.**
More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

DIPR/CP/2842/SHRDI/SAI/2026-27

**BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED**
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmasiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru - 560 052

No. DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/21/2026-27
Date: 19.09.2026

INVITATION FOR SHORT TERM TENDER (Only through GOK KPPP Portal Only) **Call-3**
The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl No	Name of the Work	Amount put to tender per annum (Rs.in Lakhs)	EMD (In Rs)	Cost of Tender Document	Contract period
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Bommanahalli division (Package-19) Call-3	2597.46	Rs.1,00,000/- through e payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/NEFT / OTC and the balance 24,97,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized /Scheduled Bank	As per e-Portal	84 Months

(1) Tender documents can be downloaded from KPP Portal: **22.09.2026** (2) Last date to upload pre-bid queries in KPP Portal: **24.09.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** (3) Tender Pre Bid meeting: **25.09.2026 at 15:00 hrs. at above mentioned office.** (4) Last Date of Receipt of Tender : **05.10.2026 before 17:00 hrs.** (5) Opening of Technical Bid: **06.10.2026 after 17:30 hrs.**
More details can be downloaded from website - <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML.

DIPR/CP/2841/SHRDI/SAI/2026-27

IN BRIEF



Rampur Hounds join India-U.S. troops for specialised drills

Indian Army's military dogs, including indigenous Rampur Hounds, are showcasing their specialised operational skills alongside U.S. Army personnel during the ongoing India-U.S. bilateral exercise Yuth Abhyas 2026. According to the Indian Army, four Army Canines - Rampur Hounds Victor and Rowdy, Belgian Malinois Zac and Labrador Retriever Rice are participating in the exercise, demonstrating their capabilities in room intervention and rappelling drills as part of the professional exchanges with the U.S. Army. Rampur Hounds are increasingly being inducted for specialised military roles. Its participation in the exercise highlights Army's efforts to employ indigenous canine breeds for operational tasks.

FPIs withdraw ₹20,974 crore from equities in September

Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) have turned cautious again, pulling out ₹20,974 crore from Indian equities so far in September amid global uncertainties, higher U.S. interest rates and bond yields, elevated crude oil prices and a weakening rupee. The latest outflow comes after foreign investors returned to Indian equities in July and August, when they invested ₹20,200 crore and ₹29,630 crore, respectively, according to data from CDSL. With the September selling, FPIs have now withdrawn a total of ₹2.45 lakh crore from Indian equities so far in 2026, surpassing the ₹1.66 lakh crore outflow recorded during the entire 2025. PH

SC calls for law to safeguard multi-crore court deposits

SC highlights absence of uniform rules governing money deposited by litigants; it says asymmetry in treating deposits is causing further pendency, wants these protected from ad-hoc management

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

A law is necessary to protect crores deposited by litigants across courts and tribunals in the country during pending appeals, the Supreme Court said in a recent judgment.

A Bench of Justices P.S. Narasimha and Alok Aradhe observed that litigants' money should be saved from ad-hoc management while calling for nationwide legislative reform to standardise how courts and tribunals handle money deposited during pending litigation.

The top court pointed out the problem of the absence of uniform rules governing court-ordered deposits. For example, a court would direct a litigant to deposit money in order to get a stay while his or her appeal is heard out.

So far, individual courts and tribunals have passed orders on deposits and their investment during the pendency of appeals on a case-to-case basis.

This, the court said, has left huge sums of money entangled in financial instruments across different banks, earning inconsis-

In order to preserve the economic integrity of any deposit and to provide interest, there must be clarity and uniformity in the method and manner in which the deposit itself is handled

SUPREME COURT BENCH



tent interest rates and triggering post-judgment litigation over the interest-accounting of their deposits.

The Bench said the pressure of inflation and economic uncertainties also add to the anxieties about rates of interest on the deposits.

"In order to preserve the economic integrity of any deposit and to provide interest, there must be clarity and uniformity in the method and manner in which the deposit itself is handled. Lack of standardisation in the process by which sums deposited into the court are to be handled undermines this essential underlying principle of the time value of money as well as the accrual of interest in a certain and clear manner," the recent verdict observed.

Further, the top court pointed out that the asymmetry in treating deposits made by litigants is leading to further pendency across courts.

"Lack of common standards and consistent principles are resulting in repeated determinations of routine questions concerning investment, renewal, quantum, accounting and interest on deposits, thereby increasing the burden on courts/tribunals," the Bench observed.

The court suggested the U.S. model of having a common platform where deposits made in courts and tribunals were pooled into one unified scheme and put into the most beneficial financial instrument for the litigating parties.

"This common platform will not only create certain-

ty in the interest rates and increase the ease of accessibility for litigants but will also ease the burden on courts/tribunals regarding how this money deposited is to be invested and dealt with," Justice Narasimha observed.

The apex court recommended a statutory framework modelled after international precedents, specifically pointing to the United States' Court Registry Investment System.

"We are of the opinion that it is necessary to evolve and formulate suitable legislation on the subject. We request the Law Commission of India to examine the issues which we have highlighted and, in the process, also consider the laws which other countries have enacted. It may be necessary for the Law Commission to consult the Reserve Bank of India, Ministry of Finance and also the nodal Ministry of Law and Justice," the apex court directed.

The Bench directed the judgment copy to be forwarded to the Law Commission chairperson; RBI Governor; and Secretaries to the Ministries of Finance, and Law and Justice.



The mangled remains of the car that plunged nearly 75 feet from the Mumbai Coastal Road on Sunday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Three youth killed as 'speeding' luxury car crashes in Mumbai

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Three youth were killed and one was critically injured on Sunday after the car they were travelling in went out of control on the Coastal Road in Mumbai and plunged nearly 75 feet into an under-construction site.

The police said the incident occurred around 5 a.m. when the luxury car was moving from Marine Drive towards north Mumbai. The driver appeared to have lost control because of high speed, the police said.

The deceased were identified as Sanay Gujar, 21; Aditya Jakasania, 19; and Dhairya Sheth, 17. Gujar was driving the car. The injured youth, Aditya Os-

wal, 23, is undergoing treatment at a hospital. He is in a critical condition.

The Mumbai Coastal Road is a 10.58-km high-speed freeway connecting Marine Drive to the Worli end of the Bandra-Worli Sea Link.

Tardeo police station senior inspector Meena Jagtap said, "It appears that the car was travelling at a very high speed and the driver lost control before the vehicle hit the Coastal Road barrier and fell, killing three students and injuring another."

Gujjar, Oswal, and Sheth were students of a management college in Vile Parle. Gujar was from Ahmedabad and was staying as a paying guest in Mumbai. The BMW belonged to his family.

Study attempts to find out how India made diabetes medicines affordable

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A study by Chennai-based diabetologists has attempted to find out how India has managed to reduce the prices of new and expensive diabetes drugs and what lessons this could possibly hold for other low- and middle-income countries (LMIC). The study, "Making Modern Diabetes Medications Affordable and Accessible: Lessons from India for Other Countries", was led by V. Mohan, chairman, Dr. Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre, Chennai, and was published in the journal *Diabetes Care*.

What did the study find? Of the 589 million adults in the world with diabetes, 80% live in LMICs, the study noted. Modern diabetes therapies such as GLP-1 re-

ceptor agonists as well as SGLT2i (sodium-glucose cotransporter 2 inhibitors) improve cardiovascular and renal outcomes, while analogue insulins help reduce the risk of hypoglycaemia. However, affordability remains a barrier: diabetes requires lifelong care and management of complications.

India's ability to maintain low medication prices is closely linked to its role as a major pharmaceutical exporter, the paper stated, noting the strategic legislative history of maintaining critical safeguards to prevent "patent evergreening" and allowing for generic manufacture of drugs. It also found that the country has increasingly focused on strengthening domestic manufacturing capacity. There are concerns over global trade policies affecting prices

and the availability of raw materials. A government incentive scheme has been introduced to promote domestic manufacturing of raw materials, and as of 2025, production has commenced for 26 molecules that were previously imported.

The paper notes that metformin and sulfonylureas continue to form the foundation of type 2 diabetes management in India — both are included in the National List of Essential Medicines (NLEM). While DPP-4 (dipeptidyl peptidase 4) inhibitors, SGLT2i and GLP-1 RA have all been introduced, they are not currently in the NLEM. Initial uptake of these drugs was constrained by pricing. Following the competitive entry by multiple domestic manufacturers, the price of semaglutide, for instance in India, has

dropped considerably, and there has been a huge increase in sales.

Quick availability of generic and biosimilar drugs, deliberate regulatory and distribution strategies such as the government's Jan Aushadhi Kendras, and market competition have allowed for affordable drugs in India, the paper highlighted.

Challenges ahead

Challenges that remain include urban-rural disparities in distribution and availability of medicines; tight regulations potentially affecting chances of drug innovation; differences in quality between generics and difficulties in maintaining strict pharmacovigilance; as well as limited formal evaluation of government schemes to look at their long-term impact on clinical outcomes.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As businesses, governments, and communities navigate the growing imperatives of climate action and sustainable development, *The Hindu*, in association with Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd. (CPCL), will host *The Hindu Sustainability Summit*, 2026 on Wednesday from 10 a.m. onwards.

Themed "CSR for a Sustainable Tomorrow", the summit will bring together leading voices from industry, government, academia, and the wider sustainability ecosystem to examine how responsible leadership, innovation, and collaboration can translate sustainability ambitions into measurable impact. The summit will be inaugurated by V.K. Rajeev, Minister for Environment



and Climate Change, Government of Tamil Nadu. H. Shankar, Managing Director, CPCL, and Kumar Jayant, IAS, Chairman and Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Ltd. (TNPL), will be the Guests of Honour.

Eight sessions

The full-day summit will feature eight insightful sessions, comprising fireside conversations, panel discussions, and presentations, bringing together di-

verse perspectives on some of the most pressing sustainability challenges and opportunities.

The discussions will explore the transformation of refineries into future-ready energy hubs, innovative approaches to wastewater management and the role of circularity in building resilient water systems.

Other sessions will examine how ESG, data and digital innovation can help drive more impactful CSR initiatives, alongside the future of sustainable cooling and process heating.

The summit will also delve into India's transition from fossil fuels to net zero, the role of start-ups in accelerating the energy transition, and how the banking sector can support the financing of a sustainable future.

A session on real estate and sustainability will exa-

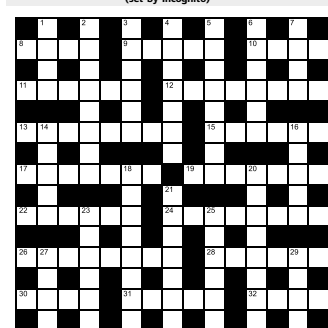
mine how the sector can balance growth with environmental responsibility.

The summit is supported by CPCL as the Presenting Partner, with NLC India Ltd., Larsen & Toubro (L&T), Navin's, WABAG, Tamil Nadu Newsprint and Papers Ltd., Indian Bank, Urbando, and State Bank of India as Associate Partners.

The summit's sustainability-focused partnerships include Thermoas as the Sustainable Cooling Partner, Treeni as the Sustainability Intelligence Partner, Chennai Port Authority as the Blue Economy Partner, and Tamil Nadu Green Climate Company as the Climate Action Partner.

Mangaldeep is the Franchise Partner, Puthiya Thalaimurai the TV Partner, The Federal the Digital TV Partner and Community the NGO Partner.

THE CROSSWORD 14903



Across

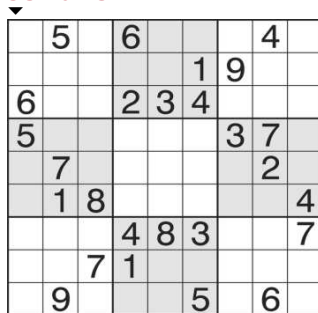
- 8 Wine from cantina stinks (4)
- 9 Worries returned in Winchester farm (5)
- 10 Fastener from damaged part removed from air plant repaired (4)
- 11 Cops from Napoli centre (6)
- 12 Non believers at theft (8)

- 13 Hence ads may be converted into money (8)
- 15 Acceptable, perhaps, to band wrongly (3,3)
- 17 Hoffman hugs boy producing receptacle for waste (7)
- 19 Zulu and Maori danced at end of season for royalty from Calicut (7)
- 22 Novelist from Australia in front of god (6)
- 24 Herons flying around setter and riders from the cavalry (8)
- 26 12 months, but longer than usual? (4,4)
- 28 Actor who played The Godfather gives up love for Yankee liquor (6)
- 30 Scotsman gets English spice (4)
- 31 Ms Adler's nurse is in anger (5)
- 32 Positive response after European sees (4)

Down

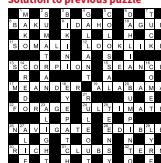
- 1 In absence of pit, topsoil destroyed in capital (4)
- 2 Watchful giant goes around port after six (8)
- 3 Female share is changed once again (6)
- 4 Sees Romeo altering grade at school (7)
- 5 Weakness afterwards in Asia (8)
- 6 Join up and throw tensile (6)
- 7 Affix foot at American soldier's backside for present (4)
- 14 Pacific island urn broken contains gold (5)
- 16 51 captured by one girl in Wonderland (5)
- 18 Some Middle-Easterners dumped silly Lear in river (8)
- 20 Unties rope before adjusting seat and performs surgery (8)
- 21 That lady mixed Bert's drink (7)
- 23 Occur from latter part of mishap near shy (6)
- 25 Masseur lurking in the shrubbery? (6)
- 27 Style covered by Michaelangelo (4)
- 29 Editor returned queen's animals (4)

SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Vidura's dharma sukshma

After the Pandavas leave for the forest, Dhritarashtra is uneasy, and seeks Vidura's advice, said Kidambi Narayanan in a discourse. He says Vidura knows dharma sukshma. Dharma sukshma goes beyond merely knowing the rules. It means a person knows how to react in a particular situation, how to analyse a situation and come to the right conclusion. Only those with experience in dealing with problems of various kinds will have dharma sukshma. Dhritarashtra is aware that Vidura has jnana, which includes knowledge of dharma too. Dhritarashtra is worried. He knows his family cannot get away unhurt if they hurt the Pandavas. Not only will they have to face the wrath of the Pandavas, but will have to deal with the displeasure of the people too. He tells Vidura that whatever Sakuni did was for the welfare of Duryodhana. But he knows that dharma was not adhered to in his court. He asks Vidura how to atone for what happened in the royal assembly.

Vidura says seeking wealth and pleasures must be within the boundaries of dharma. The foundation of governance is dharma. Dhritarashtra must not only be keen to protect his sons, but must also want to protect the Pandavas. "You are prejudiced against the Pandavas. You must come out of this mindset. A king should not covet other people's wealth. At least from now on, stop troubling the Pandavas. If the Kauravas continue to torment the Pandavas, your family will be destroyed. The Pandavas should be brought back. Yudhishtira is not ambitious. A kingdom will be safe only in the hands of such a king," Vidura tells Dhritarashtra.

MONEYWISE

India's UPI moment for insurance

Sarbjit Singh

UPI is hailed as a landmark in India's digital public infrastructure journey as it created an interoperable system allowing an entire market to function differently. The recent consultation paper on Public Insurance Registry by IRDAI has the potential to spark a similar revolution in insurance giving an opportunity to tackle information gap via a common and trusted layer of information across the ecosystem.

IRDAI laid down a roadmap with design principles, a legal anchor, a governance model and a phased implementation.

Why DPI, why now?

Insurance is still one of the last large financial sectors where policies are not accessible at a single point. Formalities such as KYC have to be done multiple times. Claims history is not easily available as it should be. Besides, consumer awareness and product comparisons still depend on a salesperson's narrative than verified information. The consultation paper moves the sector from the old adage that "insurance is sold" to a world where "insurance is also bought."

While Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha Act gives IRDAI a statutory anchor for insurance digitisation, the Digital Personal Data Protection Act provides data privacy while Bima Sugam boosts accessibility. But a connective tissue making them a unified framework was still missing which is what PIR is.

What makes design credible

The paper not only borrows the language of DPI but also discloses. Its design principles are from India's G20 Task Force on DPI - interoperable but not uniform. It has minimalist building blocks and a federated architecture with source-system primacy to ensure data stays where it is collected and not centralised.

In its proposal, Public Insurance Registry positions itself as common information layer that lets participants discover, verify and exchange insurance information consistently. With the free flow of information, the competitive advantage shifts to innovation and customer experience. Every stakeholder, including insurers and customers, has a shared role in making ecosystem more transparent.

In this regard, the governance proposal to restructure the Insurance Information Bureau (IIB) into a not-for-profit firm wholly owned by IRDAI is a critical step. With independent execution, institutional neutrality and rotating industry representation on board, it ensures PIR gains statutory legitimacy without regulatory capture. A phased rollout will focus on early, visible wins rather than an all-out sweeping mandate.

In practice

For the policyholder, PIR promises a consolidated view of every policy across life, health, motor and property. It has nominees, renewals, claims and unclaimed benefits visible in one place and portability turns real. Linkages with VAHAN and e-DAR can cut motor claim settlement and disputes. While insurers get verified policy and claims history to improve underwriting and fraud control, standardised reporting cuts compliance cost. For reinsurers and IRDAI, aggregate exposure data boosts catastrophe preparedness and oversight. For banks and government, verified coverage data leads to credit and better-targeted welfare. Above all, PIR gives the ecosystem what it always lacked - a shared, authoritative view of who is insured, for what and how well they are served.

A moment to seize

At Policybazaar, we know first-hand how much friction fragmented information creates for customers and the industry. PIR addresses the friction at its root. UPI transformed how India pays. PIR can transform how India protects itself. The industry must welcome and adopt it wholeheartedly and make it a success.

(The writer is Joint Group CEO, PB Fintech)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

In insurance, the written word means everything

When you take an insurance policy, don't go by the "leave the paperwork to us" pitch. It's your money and your family's financial well-being. Give the paperwork the diligence it deserves

BETWEEN THE LINES

K. Nitya Kalyani

Did your insurance agent or the broker just say, "Sir, you just sign the proposal form. I will take care of filling it"? And, did you say "yes"? It's a wrong move.

If the intermediary, by mistake or deliberately, fills in erroneous information, you may still be the person answering for it. You signed the proposal form and the consequences, logical or legal, can be yours.

It could be an error in your address or phone number, or a pre-existing disease deliberately concealed to hasten or smoothen policy issuance. You are the one who will live with the consequences. Your renewal notices may not reach you or your claim could be rejected.

Basic caution

Drastic? No. It's basic caution that you should read something related to a critical financial decision and outlay that you are going to sign.

The next time you take a life or health insurance policy, don't go by the "leave the paperwork to us" pitch.

It's your health, your life, your money and your family's financial well-being. Give the paperwork the diligence it deserves.

Read it. Check it. Then, sign it.

"Just sign it, I'll fill it in."

And if you say yes it is a wrong move you have made. What goes into the proposal form can come back to you later, especially when a claim or other dispute arises

Another error to avoid is going along with anyone who says, "Sir, we need not declare that you have high blood pressure in the proposal form. Policy will be delayed or they will charge higher premium..."

Both may be true.

Cost of concealment

However, every equation has two sides and that is where simple money mathematics comes in.

A higher premium for the appropriate cover after you have made full disclosure is cheaper than a repudiated claim when you have spent a few lakhs at a hospital.

Then, there is simple time mathematics.

Any insurance policy is a commitment you make as part of your long-term life plans. The time you spend filling up or at least checking the proposal form before signing it is an investment of your time, not a waste of it.

Talk evaporates

In this case, the intermediary is telling you to make a false declaration of facts.

It may be a misguided

What was promised orally across the table may be forgotten. What is written in the policy is harder to argue with when you need to establish what you were promised

move to help you and help himself but the problem is that his advice is only oral. That makes it very difficult to establish later if there is a dispute.

The same goes for oral marketing pitches stating what is covered, the terms and conditions of the policy or the returns on an insurance-and-investment product such as a unit-linked insurance policy.

What you are told may help you decide. What you sign and what the policy says may determine what happens later.

So, check that important assurances you were given are supported by the policy documents.

For example, if you are told there are no sub-limits in your policy, check the policy wordings. If you are told that some procedures are covered only after 24 months, read the list in the policy documents and confirm that it is indeed 24 and not 36 months.

If there is a discrepancy, raise it with your insurer and agent immediately. I am sure I don't have to say "in writing!"

But what if you discover

the problem only after the policy is in hand?

That is where the free-look period can give you a second opportunity to re-view your decision.

IRDAI regulations provide a 30-day free-look period for eligible life and health insurance policies, from receipt of the policy document. During this time you can review it. If you see discrepancies between what you heard and what you have got, if you have second thoughts about its suitability or your affordability or even if you have just changed your mind, you can make a written cancel request for the policy and get a refund subject to the rules.

The free-look cancellation is not a magic cure for every wrong decision or every instance of mis-selling. But it gives you a valuable window to read what you bought, compare it with what you thought you were buying and act if the two do not match.

Insurance is a product with enormous benefits. But when two parties to a contract don't have the same level of information, trust can break down.

Which is why you, as a customer, have to be more diligent. What you are told may help you decide. What you sign and what the policy says may determine what happens later. Read. Check. And learn to read between the lines.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

ETFs vs. index funds

THINKINVESTOR

Your choice of benchmark must be the large-cap index or the broadest investable index for institutional investors in the market where you can make goal-based investments

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Suppose you decide to invest in passive funds for your goal-based investments.

You must first select a benchmark index and then choose an exchange-traded fund (ETF) or an index fund on that benchmark index. In this article, we discuss the factors that you must consider when deciding between an ETF and an index fund.

Total costs

Your choice of benchmark must be the large-cap index or the broadest investable index for institutional investors in the market where you make such goal-based investments. Take the NSE 500 Index. This index also contains mid-cap and small-cap stocks that can expose you to momentum crash.

That means these stocks can crash regardless of the direction of the market. This makes the choice of the broadest index somewhat risky for goal-based investments.

Suppose you choose a large-cap index. Then, you must decide whether to pick an ETF or an index fund benchmarked to that index. If you consider the base expense ratio (BER), an ETF is cheaper than an index fund; median BER for an index fund is 0.15% compared with 0.08% for an ETF. But there are other costs to consider. You must setup a systematic investment plan (SIP) on an ETF through your trading account.

You can set up the SIP with market protection to ensure that your order is not executed at a price significantly greater than its last traded price.

If you are setting up the SIP for the number of units, then the amount debited each month will be different. If you set up the SIP for the amount, then you may have residual amount in your account, as you cannot buy fractional units.

Suppose the ETF price is ₹61, and your SIP is for ₹10,000. Then, you will get 163 units, and ₹57 will remain in your trading account.

You will also incur demat charges and other costs such as SEBI turnover fees, brokerage commission and exchange transaction fees including GST.

Index funds can allot fractional units. So, you can make use of your entire SIP amount. Also, you will not incur the other transaction charges.

Conclusion

The choice between an ETF and an index fund is more of preference than of cost. Note that ETFs can be sold real-time in the market, and the money is credited into your bank account the next day.

You must wait at least two days to receive the sale proceeds on your index funds.

(The author offers training programs for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)				
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure	
Small Finance Banks					
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75	
Equitas Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.10	7.10	7.00	
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	6.00	5.75	
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.00	8.00	7.77	
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	7.50	6.25	
Slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00	
Suroday Small Finance Bank	8.25	7.25	7.25	8.25	
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.80	7.25	7.25	7.00	
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00	
Private Sector Banks					
Axis Bank	6.50	6.25	6.50	6.50	
Bandhan Bank	7.45	7.00	7.25	5.85	
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	5.55	
CSB Bank	7.10	5.00	5.75	6.25	
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	5.75	
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50	
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.50	6.40	
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40	
ICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50	
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.10	6.50	7.10	6.75	
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65	

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)				
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure	
Public Sector Banks					
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.05	6.55	6.70	6.75	
IDBI Bank	6.85	6.20	6.35	6.25	
Karnataka Bank	7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15	
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25	
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70	
SBI Bank India	7.30	7.10	7.10	6.80	
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70	
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70	
YES Bank	7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75	
Public Sector Banks					
Bank of Baroda	6.75	6.25	6.25	6.30	
Bank of India	6.85	6.50	6.70	6.00	
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.40	5.25	5.00	
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25	
Central Bank of India	6.75	6.10	6.00	6.00	
Indian Bank	6.65	6.10	6.05	6.00	
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10	
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35	
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.85	5.85	5.85	5.95	
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05	
Union Bank of India	6.55	6.20	6.10	6.00	

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Up to 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & up to 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
Public Sector Banks			
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.00-9.90	7.00-9.90	7.00-9.90
Central Bank of India	7.00-9.15	7.00-9.15	7.00-9.15
Indian Bank	7.15-9.15	7.15-9.15	7.15-9.15
Indian Overseas Bank	7.20	7.20	7.20
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75	7.35-10.75
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
State Bank of India	7.25-8.55	7.25-8.55	7.25-8.55
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.80	7.15-9.80	7.15-9.80
Private Sector Banks			
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90
Bandhan Bank	8.55-13.52	8.55-13.52	8.55-13.52
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
CSB Bank	8.30	8.30	8.30
Federal Bank	8.35-10.50	7.35-10.50	7.35-9.50
HDFC Bank	7.75	7.75	7.75
HSBC Bank	7.45	7.45	7.45
ICI Bank	7.55	7.55	7.55

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Up to 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & up to 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
Public Sector Banks			
Karnataka Bank	7.48-11.80	7.48-11.80	7.48-11.80
Kanur Vyysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.60	7.60	7.60
RBL Bank	9.00	9.00	9.00
South Indian Bank	7.25	7.25	7.25
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90-9.30	7.90-9.30	7.90-9.30
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75	7.75	7.75
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.25	7.25	7.25
GIC Housing Finance	8.20	8.20	8.20
Godrej Housing Finance	7.85	7.85	7.85
IOCI Housing Finance	7.50	7.50	7.50
LIC Housing Finance	7.15	7.15	7.15
PNB Housing Finance	7.75-10.05	7.75-10.05	7.75-10.05
Sammam Capital	8.75	8.75	8.75
SMFG India Home Finance	9.25	9.25	9.25
Tata Capital	8.00	8.00	8.00

*Extra interest rate concession of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance policy
Rates as on September 16 | Nonwards Source: Paisabazaar.com

Sport

STRONG START

Suchika assured of bronze medal in Traditional MMA 60kg event

FILE PHOTO

Suchika Tariyal assured India of another medal at the Asian Games, beating Mongolia's Altanchimeg Baigalma 2-0 to enter the semifinals of the women's Traditional Mixed Martial Arts 60kg event on Sunday. The semifinals at the Nagoya City Inae Sports Centre on Monday will give Suchika a chance to turn her bronze into a gold.

TOPPING THE CHARTS

Smriti becomes highest run-getter in the history of women's T20Is

FILE PHOTO

India opener Smriti Mandhana became the leading run-scorer in women's T20Is during the Asian Games semifinal against Bangladesh at Nishin on Sunday. The elegant left-hander, who made a 19-ball 37, surpassed New Zealand great Suzie Bates' tally (4,758). She has an aggregate of 4,788 from 178 matches.

SO NEAR YET SO FAR

Quimcy narrowly misses bronze as India suffers double heartbreak

X@ANI, DIGITAL

India's Quimcy Dsouza lost both her bronze-medal matches in table tennis at the Asian Games in Nagoya. Quimcy went down fighting to Japan's Yuina Sakamoto 11-12, 11-12 in women's singles. The Quimcy-Mohamed Anas Beg pair lost 9-12, 6-12 to Vietnam's Hoang Minh Tan Nguyen and Gia Nghi Trinh in mixed doubles.

MAKING A SPLASH

Teen sensation Yu breaks record as China dominates swimming

REUTERS

Thirteen-year-old Yu Zidi announced herself at the Asian Games in style as the Chinese swimmers dominated the opening day of the competition being held in Tokyo. Olympic champion Pan Zhanle topped the podium as China triumphed in six of the seven finals. Yu won women's 200m butterfly with a Games record of 2:05.08s.

Elavenil stars as shooters clinch two silver medals

The senior markswoman squanders a comfortable lead to finish behind host Japan's Tanichi in 10m air rifle after opening India's account in the team event along with Sonam and Vidarsa

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan

NAGOYA

Till the midway stage, Elavenil Valarivan was placed comfortably at the top with a lead that would, on any other day, be enough to keep her there till the end. On Sunday, Elavenil, the seniormost of the three Indian women in the 10m air rifle competition here, allowed her mind to get the better of her trigger finger, settling for a silver on the opening day of the Asian Games shooting competition.

Elavenil managed a total of 252.4 points over 24 shots to finish 0.6 adrift of Hinata Tanichi, the Japanese crawling her way to the top, one shot at a time. Korea's reigning Olympic champion Ban Hyejin finished third. But once the top-three were decided, it was all about the colour of the medal. Elavenil and India, though, had already assured themselves of a team silver even before the final began. Sonam Maskar and Vidarsa K. Vinod shooting high enough in the qualifying round ensured that the three together would not go back empty-handed. Vidarsa shot 630.4 and with Sonam also qualifying for the top eight with an impressive 634.1, there were hopes of two In-



Plenty to smile: Elavenil had a big role in two podium finishes for India on the opening day of the shooting competition. R.V. MOORTHY

dians on the podium. And, for a while, the hopes seemed justified.

Sonam, in particular, had been very consistent all through the qualifying, not going below 105 in any of the six series of 10 shots

each. But one bad score on the 15th shot – a 9.9, her only bad shot of the day – ended her journey in sixth place. Elavenil, however, was in a different zone. Even as big names kept falling by the wayside – hol-



I was getting a little easy on my process, so I think I will have to get back and work on it more. It's been like this post-Paris [Olympics]. I am grateful I have been getting a lot of opportunities to learn, experiment and utilise my potential

der Han Jiayu was eliminated seventh and reigning Olympic champion and World No. 1 Wang Zefei was fifth – the 27-year-old kept increasing her lead.

Once the medalists were decided, however, it looked like Elavenil abruptly took her foot off the gas. Her scores dropped from high 10s to low 10s, she had a couple of 10.1s, and it was clear the spell had broken. Her lead at the top was still good enough to make it to the last two shots but its gradual erosion also saw her the top spot and the gold slipping away.

Earlier Vidarsa, having started strongly in the qualifications, ended with two low rounds of 104.3 and 104.4, the last two series pulling her down to 12th place.

Qualifications World Record holder Wang, meanwhile, added a new Games and Asian qualifying record to her kitty with a total of 636.8.

Vidarsa is not done yet



Tasting success: Vidarsa, Sonam and Elavenil began India's medal hunt. R.V. MOORTHY

Uthra Ganesan

NAGOYA

There is a lot Keralaam is known for, including sports. Shooting, though, isn't one of them.

For Vidarsa K. Vinod, however, that made little difference in her pursuit of a sport that has now made her a famous shooter in the State.

On Sunday, after finishing 12th in the individual competition of the 10m air rifle at the Asian Games and winning a team silver, Vidarsa had no regrets.

"I am satisfied. My main event is 50m 3P and I am confident of that," Vidarsa told *The Hindu* at the range.

For someone who started 10m air rifle only to im-

prove her standing posture in the 50m, her rapid growth in the discipline has been remarkable.

"I was actually not even expecting to participate in both events. My first competition (in 10m) was in 2025 where I scored my personal best. That is when I realised I can do both," said Vidarsa, who began shooting only in 2018 as an NCC cadet in college.

Swift rise

The rise through the ranks, even with little competi-

tion, was swift – first with in the State and then at the National level. The Asian Games, however, was a different ball game.

"After I got to know I had a chance to be selected

for the Asian Games, I was preparing mentally and physically. It took me almost eight years to achieve this and the journey was very difficult. There was a lot of struggle, self-doubt, failures... I kept asking myself whether I was on the right path and if I was doing the right thing," she had admitted in an exclusive interaction earlier in Bhopal.

Her first outing at the Games may not have been as rewarding as she would have liked but Vidarsa is ready for the long haul.

"Coming from a village where people have limited vision and ambition, I have always wanted more. I am not ready to give up in the face of failures," she promised.

I relaxed a bit, but gave my best: Elavenil

Uthra Ganesan

NAGOYA

It was not a silver won but a gold lost for Elavenil Valarivan at the Aichi General Shooting Gallery on Sunday, the 27-year-old letting a sure title chance slip away by easing up too early in the final.

The wide smile she had after the event could not hide the 'what if's' running through her mind.

"Somewhere I knew I was in the top three and although I was coming back to my process and techniques, I did get a bit relaxed.

"I really need to work on my [game in] finals. But I think I gave my absolute best," Elavenil said.

It was a candid admission by someone making her return to the Asian Games after an eight-year break, having missed out on the previous edition.

Sonam Maskar, who had only one bad shot of 9.9 through her entire competition and crashed out of medal contention, reacted similarly.

"I am not disappointed but I feel it could have been a better shot. I will work on it. I have to focus more on the process, work more on how to do better in finals".

'Medically unfit' Sanyal forced to withdraw

Uthra Ganesan

NAGOYA

Mixed Martial Arts (MMA) athlete Varun Sanyal, a late addition to the Indian squad for the Asian Games, was on Sunday forced to withdraw after being declared medically unfit for competition.

The 27-year-old, India's entry in the traditional 77kg, was found unconscious during a sauna session on the cruise ship Costa Serena while trying to cut his weight for the quarter-final fight.

He was assessed by medical personnel, diagnosed as severely exhausted and dehydrated and declared unfit to compete.

The Indian Olympic Association said: "Sanyal suffered from generalised cramps and body ache while in the sauna last evening... He underwent medical examination and precautionary blood tests, which were normal. Despite rest, the following morning, he felt not fully fit to participate.

"After consultation with his coach, he withdrew on medical grounds".

Shafali goes berserk, India to play Sri Lanka for gold

Press Trust of India

NISSHIN

Reigning champion India stormed into the women's cricket T20I final at the Asian Games for a second successive edition, confirming at least a silver medal. The Women in Blue advanced to the gold-medal match with a crushing 114-run win over Bangladesh on Sunday.

Shafali Verma peeled off her maiden T20I century, an unbeaten 100 off just 49 balls (3x4, 9x6), to power India to a formidable 195 for four. The aggressive opener was well supported by Smriti Mandhana (37, 19b, 5x4, 2x6) and skipper Harmanpreet Kaur (40, 33b, 6x4) from the other end. The Bangladesh chase unravelled almost immediately as wickets fell at regular intervals, with the side eventually getting bowled out for just 81 in 15.4 overs.

Nandani Sharma returned three for 25 and even came close to taking a hat-trick in the 11th over.

India will face Sri Lanka in the gold-medal match on Tuesday, in a repeat of last edition's final.



Power and panache: Shafali's unbeaten century was studded with three fours and nine sixes. @BCCWOMEN

THE INDIA SHOW

A look at some Indian performances on Sunday:

Badminton: Women's team (round-of-16): bt Kazakhstan 3-0.

Cricket: Women (semifinal): bt Bangladesh by 114 runs.

Hockey: Women (Pool B): bt Uzbekistan 19-0; Men (Pool A): bt Indonesia 13-1.

Mixed Martial Arts: Women's Traditional -60kg (quarterfinal): Suchika bt Baigalma (Mgl) 2-0.

Shooting: Women (final): 10m air rifle individual: Elavenil (silver), Sonam (sixth); Team: Silver (Elavenil, Sonam, Vidarsa).

Swimming: Men: 100m

freestyle: Benedictov (12th overall), DNQ for final, Akash (23rd overall), DNQ for final; 100m backstroke: Rishabh (sixth in the final), Utkarsh (12th overall), DNQ for final.

Table tennis: Women's team (Group F): bt Indonesia 3-0; bt Singapore 3-2, Men's team (Group F): bt Indonesia 3-0; lost to Iran 0-3.

Table tennis: Women's singles bronze match: Quimcy lost to Sakamoto (Jpn) 0-2; Mixed doubles bronze match: Quimcy & Anas lost to Nguyen & Trinh (Vie) 0-2.

Wushu: Men's Changquan final: Suraj (11th).

Deepti (3/7).

Toss: India.

Pakistan 177/4 in 20 overs lost to Sri Lanka 178/2 in 17.5 overs.

Toss: Sri Lanka.

India blanks Kazakhstan, sets up clash with Japan

Press Trust of India

NAGOYA

India cruised past a lowly Kazakhstan 3-0 in the badminton women's team event at the Asian Games on Sunday, setting up a challenging quarterfinal against host Japan.

At the Ichinomiya City Municipal Gymnasium, P.V. Sindhu, Unnati Hooda and Tanvi Sharma completed a sweep without dropping a game.

The road from here is set to be a difficult one for India, which had returned empty-handed from Hangzhou in 2023.

"We have a good team. Japan is also good and strong, so it is going to be a tough one," Sindhu said about the upcoming clash.

"A lot of girls are playing at the Asian Games for the first time, so I am taking it (leadership) in a responsible way," the two-time Asian medalist added.

The results: India bt Kazakhstan 3-0 (P.V. Sindhu bt Kamila Smagulova 21-7, 21-9; Unnati Hooda bt Alissa Kuleshova 21-7, 21-10; Tanvi Sharma bt Diana Namenova 21-5, 21-10).

India's hockey teams maul their opponents

Press Trust of India

KAKAMIGAHARA

Defending champion India produced a brilliant all-round performance led by striker Dilpreet Singh's four-goal haul to outplay unfancied Indonesia 13-1 in its opening men's Pool A match of the Asian Games here on Sunday.

Not to be left behind, young striker Deepika Sehrawat slammed in a record-shattering eight goals as the Indian women hammered lowly Uzbekistan 19-0 in a Pool B game.

All of Dilpreet's strikes were field goals while Shilanand Lakra and Sukhjeth Singh scored a brace each.

Dilpreet credited the team effort and said that the focus was on winning gold and ensuring a direct



Field day: Indian women put 19 past Uzbekistan. HOCKEYINDIA

INDIANS IN ACTION

A look at some Indian players/teams who will compete on Monday (all times IST):

BADMINTON

Men's team (round-of-16): vs. Bangladesh, 11.30 a.m.

BOXING

Men's 70kg (round-of-32): Sumit vs. Bunjong (Tha), 2.45 p.m.

HOCKEY

Women (Pool B): vs. Indonesia, 9.30 a.m.

KABADDI

Men (Group A): vs. Japan, 9.45 a.m.; Women (Group A): vs. Bangladesh, 4.15 p.m.

MIXED MARTIAL ARTS

Women's Traditional -60kg (semifinal): Suchika vs. Hoon (Sgp), 8.30 a.m.

SHOOTING

Men: 10m air rifle individual qualification and team final (Himanshu, Parth, Rudraksh); 6.15 a.m.; individual final, 9 a.m.; Skeet individual qualification and team final - Day 1 (Mairaj, Anantjeet, Bhavtegh), 6.30 a.m.; Women: Skeet individual qualification and team final - Day 1 (Parinaaz, Raiza, Maheshwari), 6.30 a.m.

SWIMMING

Men: Heats (from 6.30 a.m.); 50m backstroke (Rishabh, Srihar); 100m freestyle (Akash, Heer); 50m breaststroke (Danush); 4x200m freestyle relay; finals (from 1.30 p.m.).

TABLE TENNIS

Women's team (Group F): vs. Pakistan, 6.30 a.m.; Men's team (Group F): vs. Pakistan, 3.30 p.m.

WUSHU

Women's Changquan final: Wangsu, 5.30 a.m.

INBRIEF



Niki's all-round show powers India-A past Australia-A

Niki Prasad, *in pic.*, started with the ball and bat (three for 28 and 32 n.o.) as India-A defeated Australia-A by four wickets in the first one-dayer at Mohali on Sunday. Put in to bat, the visiting side was bowled out for 235 in the 47th over. Tejal Hasabnis made 81 and Anushka Sharma scored 55 as the host romped home with 53 balls to spare to go one up in the three-match series.

The scores: Australia-A 235 in 46.3 overs (Tahila Wilson 48, Vaishnavi Sharma 3/40, Niki Prasad 3/28) lost to India-A 239/6 in 41.1 overs (Tejal Hasabnis 81, Anushka Sharma 55). **Toss:** India-A.

Sambudula bags two races in F4 second round

Goa Aces JA Racing's Luviwe Sambudula won two races in second round of the F4 Indian championship, part of the Indian Racing Festival, at the Kari Motor Speedway in Coimbatore on Sunday. Hyderabad Blackbirds' Bhuvan Bonu was the other winner coming out on top in the reverse-grid race. Kichcha's Kings Aris Kyriakou retained the championship lead after securing three podium finishes across the weekend, while Sambudula's two victories moved him closer to the top of the standings.

Fleming says 'wrong' to ask Stokes to end retirement

Newly appointed England Test coach Stephen Fleming says it would be "wrong" to ask former captain Ben Stokes to reverse his international retirement before next year's Ashes. "He seemed to be really at peace with his decision. To try to turn that around and question that is wrong".

LIVE TELECAST

Asian Games: Day 4, Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)
Crickets: Asian Games (Women), Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Hanumanmahabala should score an encore in the feature event

DERABAD: The four-year-old colt Hanumanmahabala, who won well in his last start, should score an encore in the Raja Mahboob Karan Memorial Trophy, the main event of Monday's (Sept. 20) races.

1. GREEN HAVEN PLATE (Div. I) (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated upto 25 (Cat. III) no whip, 1.35 p.m.: 1. Exclusive Luck (8) Antony Raj 62, 2. Faizah (7) V.S. Shekhawat 61.5, 3. Shreshtha (2) D.S. Deora 61.5, 4. Sugriva (5) Mohit 61, 5. Char Ek Char (9) Surendra 59.5, 6. Bien Pensant (6) Surya Prakash 59, 7. Dhanraj (4) Nihal 57.5, 8. Ranger (1) B. Nikhil 57.5, 9. Amboseli (4) Rafique Star 53 and 9. Iconic Star (3) Bhavani S 52.5.

1. EXCLUSIVE LUCK, 2. ICONIC STAR, 3. FAIZAH

2. GREEN HAVEN PLATE (Div. II) (1,200m), 4-y-o and upward, rated upto 25 (Cat. III) no whip, 2.10 p.m. The Purpose (6) R.N. Darshan 62, 2. Marissa (8) Uday Kiran 61.5, 3. Star Councillor (3) D.S. Deora 61.5, 4. Bold Indian (4) Sohan K 60, 5. Golden Inzo (5) Arjun 59.5, 6. Country's Maximus (9) Rafique Star 58, 7. Mirzeta (7) Surendra 58, 8. Hopewell Island (1) Bhawani S 53 and 9. Niloufer The Great (2) Arjun 50.

1. THE PURPOSE, 2. BOLD INDIAN, 3. STAR COUNCILLOR

3. SHIV KUMAR LAI MEMORIAL TROPHY (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, rated upto 45 (Cat. III), 2.45: 1. Hoping Star (3) Sohan K 60, 2. Master Class (2) Gaurav 60, 3. Gold Touch (7) Arjun 59.5, 4. You Tuber (6) Akshay K 58.5, 5. Zorba (9) P. Ajeeth K 56.5, 6. Aquatone (4) B. Nikhil 54, 7. Crimson Rose (1) Surya Prakash 53.5 and 8. Ruby Tuesday (8) G. Nareesh 51.

1. YOU TUBER, 2. HOPING STAR, 3. ZORBA

4. MEDAK PLATE (1,400m), (Terms) Maiden, 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 3.20 p.m. Atman (8) Antony Raj 56, 2. Holy Tiger (1) Surya Prakash 56, 3. Noble Pella (3) Kuldeep Sr. 56, 4. Stronghold (9) Shivam 56, 5. Twilight King (2) P. Ajeeth K 56, 6. Wesethes amesun (4) Rafique Star 56, 7. Wind Castle (7) P. Sai K 56, 8. Akashraka (13) Santosh Raj 54.5, 9. Anemara (6) Akshay K 54.5, 10. Ashwa Jaffa (15) Gaurav 54.5, 11. Bodhi (1) Md. Ismail 54.5, 12. Grit N'

Polish women make a habit of beating India

Vaishali's loss to Maltsevskaia on the second board proves vital as the defending champion goes down 1.5-2.5; Pragg and Gukesh's wins do it for the titlist in the fifth round of the open section

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

History repeated itself at the Chess Olympiad on Sunday.

Poland defeated the top-seeded India in the women's event 2.5-1.5 at Samarkand; it was the exact scoreline in Budapest two years ago. That loss had come in the eighth round. India, however, bounced strongly back to win the title. This time around, it happened in the fifth round, and the defeat is indeed a setback to the defending champion.

After the games involving Koneru Humpy, Divya Deshmukh and Vantika Agrawal were all drawn, the fate of the match rested on the second-board clash between R. Vaishali and Aleksandra Maltsevskaia. The Chennai Grandmaster, with black pieces, was three pawns down when she resigned on the 57th move.

Vaishali's younger brother R. Pragganandhaa, however, scored an important win for India in the open section. He defeated Anish Giri, as the reigning champion won the match against the Netherlands 3-1.

D. Gukesh also won, while there were draws for Arjun Erigaisi and Nihal Sarin. The open event also



Crucial result: Pragganandhaa held his own against the Netherlands' Anish. FIDE



In the zone: Gukesh is a picture of concentration. FIDE

saw Germany pull off a shocking 2.5-1.5 win over top-seeded United States.

Important results (fifth

round):
Open: India bt Netherlands 3-1 (R. Pragganandhaa bt Anish Giri; Arjun Erigaisi drew with Jorden van Foreest; Nihal Sarin drew

with Loek van Wely; D. Gukesh bt Erwin L'Ami).
Uzbekistan bt Hungary 4-0; Germany bt USA 2.5-1.5; Armenia drew with China 2-2.

France bt Czechia 2.5-1.5; England bt Georgia 2.5-1.5; Iran bt Lithuania 3-1; Ukraine bt Montenegro 3.5-0.5; Turkey bt Latvia 3.5-0.5; Serbia bt Cuba 3-1; Poland bt Vietnam 2.5-1.5.

Women: Poland bt India

2.5-1.5 (Koneru Humpy drew with Olivia Kiolbasa; R. Vaishali lost to Aleksandra Maltsevskaia; Divya Deshmukh drew with Klaudia Kulon; Vantika Agrawal drew with Socko Monika).

USA drew with Uzbekistan 2-2; Kazakhstan bt Germany 2.5-1.5. China bt Bulgaria 3-1; Azerbaijan bt Serbia 3-1; Netherlands drew with Switzerland 2-2; Georgia bt Indonesia 2.5-1.5.

Ukraine bt Austria 2.5-1.5; France bt Slovakia 3-1; Mongolia bt Croatia 2.5-1.5.
Armenia bt Peru 3-1; Hungary bt Brazil 3-1.



Star performer: Savitha Shri has been on fire at the Olympiad, winning four successive games. FIDE

I approach Vaishali whenever I have a doubt: Savitha Shri

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

She was a wisp of a girl when she faced Magnus Carlsen in a simultaneous display ahead of the Norwegian's World championship match against Viswanathan Anand in the city back in 2013.

B. Savitha Shri has come a long way since and is currently among the top Indian women chess players. A bronze medalist at the World Rapid championship in 2022, the 19-year-old WGM is making the right moves at the ongoing Olympiad in Samarkand.

She has been the star performer, winning all four games on the fourth board before being rested for Sunday's fifth-round match against Poland.

The Chennai player, who trains under R.B. Ramesh, said the coach had been a great support and helped her make giant strides. "He (Ramesh sir)

analyses games and offers psychological support. We work a lot on the middle and end-game," Savitha Shri had told *The Hindu*.

On his part, Ramesh said, "Over the board, she does the most practical things without much hesitation when most players would hesitate."

The work put in with the acclaimed coach appears to be paying off at the Olympiad, and there is no one happier than her father Krishnan Baskar.

The teenager said World championship challenger R. Vaishali was like an "elder sister" and was always ready to help. "I approach Vaishali akka whenever I have any doubt. She gives me advice and I look up to her."

Having matched wits with someone who would go on to become one of the greatest-ever, Savitha Shri is now holding her own against the game's elite as she aims for the sky.

Powar lends Australia under-19 spinners a hand

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Former India off-spinner Ramesh Powar has joined the Australia u-19 team, helping out its young spinners. Powar joined the squad on Sunday and will spend four days with the team, including Wednesday's final youth ODI against India.

"The Australian team management approached me quite a few months back to come and spend some time with the young spinners and guide them, so I decided to spend four days with them," Powar told *The Hindu*. "It's a one-off gig, and just a short one to guide the young bowlers," he said.

Powar, a former India women's head coach, is al-



Powar, SHAYAN ACHARYA



It's a one-off gig, and just a short one to guide the young bowlers

so tipped to become the next chairman of the National junior selection committee.

Manal bounces back after failing to make it to under-19 WC team

YOUTH ODI SERIES

Shayan Acharya
RAJKOT

Manal Chauhan started playing cricket for a simple reason — he wanted to bunk school.

He would tell his parents he was going to school and head off to play cricket instead.

"At that time, I was not that interested in the sport, but I kept playing," Manal told *The Hindu* ahead of Monday's second youth ODI between India under-19 and the Australian colts here.

"Gradually, I realised that there were age-group divisions and that you move forward through them and then play for the State. I became very interested in it, so I started giv-



Simple plan: Manal is taking it one step at a time. SHAYAN ACHARYA

ing it my full time."

The boy from Morena has since led Madhya Pradesh to its maiden Cooch Behar Trophy title and made his India u-19 debut on the Sri Lanka tour, scoring 150 and an unbeaten 51 in the second youth Test.

there would be further bilateral series like this," he said. His parents and coaches told him there would be more opportunities. "I thought that, at least, I would win the red-ball tournament for MP. I did not know that I would come this far from there."

Madhya Pradesh did win the Cooch Behar Trophy. Then came the India call-up. "The biggest learning has been that things will keep going up and down in life, but you have to stick to your work ethic," he said.

Chandrakant Pandit has helped him work on the mental side of the game, while India u-19 coach Viree Goud taught him to forget mistakes and move on.

Manal is doing just that, taking it one step at a time.

Match starts at 9 a.m.

I couldn't process what was happening: Neeraj on his injury



Unfortunate: Neeraj's ligament injury ruled him out of the Asian Games. FILE PHOTO

ATHLETICS

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India's star javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra termed his absence from the Asian Games unfortunate but said it was important to "accept" the setback and focus on making a quick comeback. The 28-year-old missed out on a chance to complete a hat-trick of Asian Games gold medals after suffering a ligament injury while training.

The injury came soon after Neeraj produced a season-best throw of 88.05m at the Lausanne Diamond League, bringing his 2026 competitive season to an early end.

"It is definitely difficult. I wouldn't say it is easy," he said on the *KheLo Bharat Podcast* of the Sports Authority of India (SAI).

"It has become a little normal for me because this has happened quite a few times in my career. There have been times when I was very well prepared and suddenly suffered an injury."

"Even after winning many things, you still feel that if you had been able to use that time without the injury, perhaps even better things could have happened."

Neeraj said the latest injury was particularly frustrating because he felt he had finally returned to his best after recovering from an earlier setback.

"When I felt that I was finally back to being the old Neeraj again, with the same enthusiasm and consistency, I threw 88 metres. Then, just a day later, I got injured again during training. The first few minutes were very difficult for me. I couldn't process what was happening," he said.

Asked what he would tell Indian athletes competing at the Asian Games, Neeraj urged them to make the most of a rare opportunity.

"I would simply tell them to give their best. You get opportunities like the Games once every four years, so don't leave with anything in your mind that makes you feel later, 'I could have done this,'" he said.

Abhishek's Zen state — India's pride, world's envy

The 26-year-old has burst forth as a modern-day six-hitting behemoth against whom the margin for error is miniscule and to whom clearing the boundary is child's play



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

R. Kaushik

In an era where opening the batting in Test cricket revolved around giving the first hour, if not the first session, to the bowlers, K. Srikanth was a glorious exception to the established rule. High on risk and therefore a little short on consistency, the maverick from Tamil Nadu was unstoppable when in the mood, treating the best fast bowlers in the world with utter disdain.

Mark Greatbatch at the 1992 World Cup, and Sanath Jayasuriya in 1996, are often eulogised for changing the face of opening the batting, but long before these two left-handers left their mark, Srikanth had made hitting over the top fashionable. With complete and utter disregard for reputations, and with a nonchalance that comes only to the chosen few.

Strategies chalked at team meetings, he was told, need not concern him. First Sunil Gavaskar, and then Kapil Dev, encouraged Srikanth to be himself, to bat with natural flair and flamboyance. No one expected him to bat like Gavaskar, studied in defence and treating each ball

assiduously on its merit because, well, he wouldn't be Srikanth then, would he? And so, the right-hander went on a rampage whenever he could.

Not an accurate picture
A Test average of 29.88 from 43 matches, and a 50-over international average of 29.01 spread across 145 innings, do not paint an accurate picture of the potential for mayhem that he possessed. Srikanth was a lot more than the sum of his six international hundreds and the highest individual tally in a low-scoring final of the 1983 World Cup, because the entertainment he provided and the value he brought with him to the batting crease were beyond parallel in that time and age.

Srikanth was a pioneer, without question, his brand of batsmanship unique and remarkably enviable in his time in international cricket. The subsequent emergence of a host of destructive openers, among them a certain Sachin Tendulkar who was thrust into the role of an ODI opener almost accidentally in 1994 and who went on to finish with 49 international tons in the 50-over version, is a back-handed

compliment to the Srikanth school of aggression that has gained immense currency in the last two and a quarter decades, from the time the 20-over iteration stormed cricketing consciousness.

Virender Sehwag and Chris Gayle made a name for themselves by beautifully fusing untold havoc with stunning consistency. Both openers, the former converted from a middle-order practitioner, signed off with two Test triple tons apiece - with only the great Don Bradman and Brian Lara for company in that exclusive club of four - to reiterate that aggressive batting need not be at the expense of sustained masterpieces.

Having grown up watching the deeds of these two stalwarts, among others, Abhishek Sharma has now burst forth as a modern-day six-hitting behemoth against whom the margin for error is miniscule and to whom clearing the boundary boards is little more than child's play.

Abhishek is now 26, still some way short of hitting his peak as a batter. Internationally, he figures in only one format and it is only a matter of time before he is allowed to spread his wings and dot the 50-over landscape too with spectacular edifices. But even in that one limited-overs format, he has showcased a penchant for the bold and the beautiful that is impossible to miss.

Numerous batters who have failed to tickle the scorers in their first international innings have had a stellar career, not least the legendary G.R. Vishwanath, who followed up nought in the first innings of his debut Test against Australia in Kanpur in 1969 with 137 of the best in the second dig. Abhishek's international career too got off to the most inauspicious of beginnings - he fell for a second-ball duck against Zimbabwe in Harare in July 2024 - but the very next day, he made the world sit up and take notice by smashing a 47-ball century against the same opponents, now thoroughly shell-shocked.

It was evident even at that early stage that this was a special talent that needed to be encouraged rather than fettered, that was best left to its own devices so that he could learn from his mistakes and polish the rough edges instead of being instructed to redefine his high-risk approach. Abhishek took some time in striking the right balance between all-out attack and judiciousness in shot-selection, but once he found the magic formula, he has been an unstoppable force at the highest level.

Abhishek has played 58 T20I innings, which is a fairly reasonable sample size. Despite taking the fight to the bowlers, he has blasted three hundreds and 12 half-centuries. Despite his propensity to hit the ball in the air, he averages 33.17. And because he loves dismantling attacks and bruising egos, he has been able to strike at an extraordinary 194.55, laced with 182 fours and 126 sixes.

Every year since its inception, the Indian Premier League rewards the highest scorer of the season with the Orange Cap. In so many ways, that is incongruous because T20 cricket is seldom about quantum. It is about impact, it's about the value of the runs made. Given that eight-ball 25s are seen as being more crucial than 35-ball half-centuries, strike-rate would appear to be a logical route to deciding the significance of a batter to his team's fortunes, but strike-rate alone can't be the criterion if it rewards only cameos and disregards more meaningful contributions.

Various quarters have advocated using average and strike-rate in tandem to decide the worth of a batter. The former is a marker of consistency, the latter a pointer to explosiveness. In Abhishek's case, combining the average and the strike-rate in T20Is will give him a whopping total of 227.72. Now, while that is just a number, it is a more accurate reflection of the kind of havoc he can wreak. Abhishek's latest epic came on Thursday night at the National capital's Arun Jaitley Stadium. In the last of three T20Is that Afghanistan hosted against India in India last Thursday, Abhishek's most unforgiving avatar was on full view. In a mere 30 deliveries, he raced to his third T20I century, a good 19 months after his previous ton, against England in Mumbai in February 2025.

The hundred included nine fours and 10 sixes - 96% of his runs came in boundaries - and by the time he was dismissed, he had added one more six in his final score of 108, off a ridiculous 34 balls. It is the fastest T20I hundred against a full-member nation, the fastest ton internationally in the 20-over game by a batter from a full-member country.

Quips that Abhishek defeated the Afghans by 14 runs weren't just cute. They aptly illustrated the full weight of his dominance against a bowling group that is pedestrian by no stretch of the imagination. Afghanistan might be a little undercooked when it comes to batting in the topmost echelons, but as a bowling unit, they hardly suffer in comparison. Rashid Khan, Fazalhaq Farooqi, Mujeeb Ur Rahman and Mohammad Nabi form a formidable quartet, but Abhishek left



Abhishek's latest epic came at the National capital's Arun Jaitley Stadium. In the last of three T20Is that Afghanistan hosted against India in India, his most unforgiving avatar was on full view. In a mere 30 deliveries, he raced to his third T20I century, a good 19 months after his previous ton, against England in Mumbai in February 2025

them quivering in their collective boots, waiting for and ruthlessly punishing any indiscretion in length or direction with the most scything, punitive of willows.

In the two preceding matches of the series at the same venue, Abhishek had reeled off scores of 82 (32b) and 39 (19b) respectively. His lowest strike-rate (205.26) came in game two, sandwiched between similar efforts of 256.25 and 317.64, the latter killing any competitive interest in the dead rubber just a quarter of the way into the no-contest.

It was Abhishek at his majestic best, unhurried and unfustered, using a strong base as his ally and carefully eschewing the premeditation that has left many a batter horribly out of position. Abhishek seldom uses exaggerated feet movement whilst waiting for the bowler to deliver the ball, nor does he often seek recourse to the unconventional such as the reverse-scoop or a switch hit.

His areas of preference are in front of square rather than behind it. A beautiful bat-swing with the willow on the downward curve can be mesmerising and because Abhishek strikes the ball cleanly and down the ground, it's more than likely that he will forever be one step ahead of the opposition. The effortlessness with which he sends the ball soaring deep into the stands is audaciously breathtaking in its simplicity and for the debilitating (for the bowlers) outcome from which there is no recovery.

The very nature of the T20 beast is such that it is almost an antidote to consistency. The consensus is that opening batters are best placed to stack up all the records, and there is no arguing with that because, after all, they are in a position to play more deliveries than those succeeding them in the batting order. But the propensity to push the envelope manifests itself in greater risk-taking when the field restrictions are in place, which automatically brings with it the threat of courting cheap dismissals.

Conservatism has been thrown out of the window a long time back. India are the leaders, in a manner of speaking, in setting the tone, having woken up to the demands of the format a little later than some others, and have now meticulously pieced together an amazing set of destroyers with Abhishek as the primary wrecking ball. The Afghanistan series saw him at his fiercely consistent best. He had a reasonably forgettable T20 World Cup; three ducks at the start were only marginally offset by a blazing half-century in the final, but he seems to have rediscovered his mojo now, which is an excellent sign with the Asian Games gold medal defence now exactly a week away.

Furious competition

Abhishek will be keen to show that there is more to him than just a 20-over marauder. There is furious competition for top-order places in the 50-over setup, with someone like Yashasvi Jaiswal, who has two hundreds in his last three ODI innings, struggling to break through. Abhishek's List A (domestic 50-over) record isn't trifling - he averages 33.78 while striking at 100.18 in 68 innings - but while he will be keen to evolve as a multi-format performer, he won't lose any sleep over his longer-version future.

For now, his calling is in T20s and that's where he will try to maximise his efficacy and get the team off to the kind of starts they have come to take for granted. He won't be fazed by the fact that Vaibhav Sooryavanshi is breathing down his neck, or that there are other acknowledged ball-bashers aspiring for higher honours. Abhishek has found his Zen state - India's pride, the rest of the world's envy.

THE GIST

Abhishek took some time in striking the right balance between all-out attack and judiciousness in shot-selection, but once he found the magic formula, he has been an unstoppable force at the highest level

He has played 58 T20I innings, which is a fairly reasonable sample size. Despite taking the fight to the bowlers, he has blasted three hundreds and 12 half-centuries

Since the southpaw strikes the ball cleanly and down the ground, it's more than likely that he will forever be one step ahead of the opposition



Behind every treated animal stands a veterinarian carrying unseen strain

Unlike human medicine, where every organ often has its own specialist, veterinary medicine asks one person to be all of them at once

Vasini Varadan

While much of society is preoccupied with animal rights, there is a population facing a significant risk of burnout yet which often goes unacknowledged: veterinarians.

Often underestimated as a profession and underfunded as a field, veterinary medicine carries expectations that far exceed what can reasonably be asked of any one individual. Veterinarians are expected to deliver unwavering care, often at the cost of their own.

Like all healthcare professionals, they navigate long hours, emergencies, and loss. But they also have distinct challenges. Their patients cannot speak, forcing vets to rely on instinct as much as expertise. They must master multiple anatomies across species. They absorb not only the suffering of animals, but also the emotional intensity of anxious, grieving pet owners. And uniquely, they carry the burden of deciding when a life should end, often without adequate emotional support for the weight of the decisions made and the grief that comes with executing it.

What they experience is not simply burnout, a condition caused by prolonged stress, but also compassion fatigue (from caring unconditionally) and moral injury (having to make decisions that go against their core moral beliefs). Over time, all of this takes a toll.

Unlike human medicine, where every

organ has its own specialist, veterinary medicine asks one person to be all of them at once. Across a single day, they shift roles constantly: diagnosing, fixing, reassuring, improvising. It's not just about treating animals, it's about carrying an entire system of care in one body, adapting to whatever walks (or is carried) through the door.

Alongside their patients, vets take on the emotional aftermath, anger, disappointment, and grief of pet owners. They linger long after the consultation ends. A euthanasia need not end the day. It is often followed by the next appointment with no space or time in between to process the loss or the weight of the decision.

The rise of alternative medicine which is often cheaper brings another consequence: time lost. If the alternate treatment has not worked, there is delay in diagnosis, treatment and loss of life which falls at the hands of the vet.

Burnout, compassion fatigue, and moral injury show up in both mind and body as insomnia, brain fog, exhaustion, memory lapses and sometimes other physical illnesses.

Their work is not the problem. Most vets still care deeply about healing. It is a system defined by overwork, emotional labour, a variety of pressures, tough decisions, and financial limitations: it is meant to support them but often does the opposite.

(Vasini Varadan is a cartoonist and illustrator. vasini@varadan@gmail.com)



Like all healthcare professionals, vets navigate long hours, emergencies, and loss. But they also face distinct challenges. Representative image. MIKHAIL NILOV/PEXELS



A study found that poachers consistently targeted 'charismatic' and high-value species, such as macaws, at unsustainable rates. GETTY IMAGES

Urban demand is reorganising global wildlife trafficking web

Divya Gandhi

Some 2,000 km away from their natural habitat in the rainforests of Borneo and Sumatra, five listless baby orangutans were found, bafflingly, in a forest in the middle of Odisha on September 8. Videos were shared widely showing the critically endangered apes, each around a year old, with limited mobility, huddled together, chomping on bananas from a container. Then more videos emerged of the group being bottle-fed in a Bhubaneswar Zoo, where they are now being monitored.

Jose Louies, CEO of the Wildlife Trust of India, said it is clear these animals had been kept in captivity for a while, going by their complete lack of fear of humans. CITES prohibits the commercial trade in orangutans but these animals are routinely sold as exotic pets and can cost up to ₹20 lakh each. The discovery has renewed discourse on wildlife trafficking. India's Wildlife Crime Control Bureau has been asked to investigate the matter. There are many enigmas: How were they trafficked? By sea? Air? Road? Who captured and smuggled them? And who are their collectors? This is not the first time these apes have been found in India. In 2022, two baby orangutans were found abandoned near the Assam-Mizoram border.

A study published in the *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* has integrated 30 years of confiscation data and spatial network analysis to unravel the trade routes of another much-trafficked species, Mexico's parrots, from biodiverse habitats to urban centres around the world, and could provide clues to criminal networks in other parts of the world.

Today, urban centres are the nexuses of demand, the paper added. "For many commonly traded species, confiscations occurred hundreds of kilometers from their native habitats, frequently in major cities like Mexico City." And this demand is reorganising the global wildlife trafficking network.

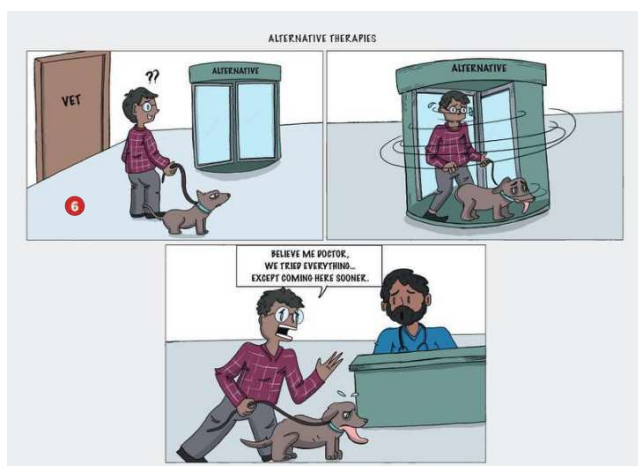
No less than half of Mexico's native parrot species are directly threatened by the illegal wildlife trade, the researchers said, "elevating their risk of extinction". They found that poachers consistently targeted "charismatic" and high-value species, particularly macaws and Amazon parrots.

The team's methods can be adapted to map other complex illicit networks, such as the trafficking of timber, marine life or even drugs and weapons. Drug cartels in Mexico also often run illegal logging operations, sharing transport logistics and laundering illicit timber alongside narcotics, the paper said.

Illicit wildlife networks are converging with broader organised crime, and criminal networks that "are complex, adaptive, and largely invisible, making them notoriously difficult to map, track, and disrupt," said the authors. And this, it added, needs a new approach "to move from enforcement-based, isolated seizures to a predictive understanding of network structure and vulnerability."

The lacunae in understanding mechanisms that feed criminal networks comes in the way of law enforcement, the team added, adding that illegal wildlife trade "comprises global, multibillion-dollar criminal enterprises that threaten biodiversity and elevate the risk of zoonotic disease transfer and emergence".

As for India, primates, turtles, and lizards are the most smuggled illegal species into the country, Dr. Jose told *The Hindu*, primarily through land routes between India and Myanmar. "The criminal network is amoebic in nature: it configures and re-configures to safeguard the business," he said.



For feedback and suggestions for 'Science', please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject 'Daily page'